

Lola, A Novel

Volume IV of La Recherche

Preface

The reader is asked to distrust the furniture.

This book arrives as romance, record, exhibit, confession, relic, and love letter, each taking its turn at the mirror and each pretending, for a sentence or two, to be the honest one. Daniel writes from the first enclosure, on his birthday, before the warrant has become fully legible to him and before the later rooms have named their uses for the pages. He does not yet know the whole case. That ignorance is not a defect in the design. It is one of the locks.

The notes are not neutral. They have read farther than the man with the felt-tip pen. They carry graphs, glossaries, cross-references, and the chilly little confidence of arrangement. They are also implicated. A note can preserve a sentence; it can also teach the sentence how to pose.

Lola remains the danger to both operations. She is not safely the beloved, the witness, the victim, the muse, the girl in peril, the clever student, the future fiancée, or the figure required by anyone's theory. She appears where the record allows her to appear: with questions, errands, jokes, fear, tenderness, fatigue, and the right to exceed the page that wants to hold her.

Read the messages as evidence only after reading them as messages. Read the romance as romance only after noticing how eagerly romance asks to be excused. Read the footnotes last, then suspect them first.

Prologue

[ANNOTATOR]

These pages begin before the case has learned to speak fluently. Daniel writes from the first enclosure, not the last one: arrested, numbered, listening to official voices practice his name, not yet knowing the warrant as a finished object.

The notes must be read with suspicion. They are not neutral corrections beside a confession. They are part of the artwork and part of the danger: an apparatus arranging materials that may condemn the man who arranged them first.

The charts, tables, graphs, glossaries, and concordances do not belong to Daniel's yellow-pad memory. They belong to the Annotator: not counsel, but carrier, preparing exact words for a court this book will not yet name. He is not counsel for Daniel's acquittal and not counsel against Lola. His material is route, recurrence, and liability: who spoke, who received, what was preserved, what was lost, what form a phrase took, what consequence it carried, and what judgment it risked when moved from message to screenshot, report, fear, law, and art. Selection is already custody, though the later court has not yet taught him the word.

The Annotator has read beyond this room and may cross-reference later chambers because the archive now exists as a series. Daniel's jail voice does not have that knowledge. There are three presences here: the jail voice, the notes, and Lola where the materials allow her to speak. None receives final

possession. Lola has the rarer power of interrupting both by remaining partly unconverted into either story.

[GRAPH] Caption: Figure 1. The Annotator's monthly scale problem: scale is not acquittal, but the later accusation must not pretend it was born alone. Path: output/graphs/prologue_monthly_volume.png

[GRAPH] Caption: Figure 2. Daily volume: March appears in red, visible but not original; volume becomes weather before it becomes charge. Path: output/graphs/prologue_daily_volume.png

[GRAPH] Caption: Figure 3. Selected charged words. The chart does not define them; it summons the words whose offices changed. Path: output/graphs/prologue_charged_words.png

[YELLOW PAD]

Ladies and gentlemen, if I have imagined you, forgive the upholstery. One must put the voice somewhere.

I have no courtroom yet, only a room with a bunk, a felt-tip pen, and a birthday that has become less charming by the hour. Still, the mind arranges itself theatrically when frightened. It invents chairs. It invents attention. It invents a jury because a jury, unlike a lover, is at least required to listen before it leaves.

I will tell you the story as I saw it.

That is not the same as telling you the truth. It is not necessarily the opposite either. Truth, in a matter like this, behaves less like a jewel than like a body under changing light. Turn it once and it is romance. Turn it again and it is exhibit. Turn it under ultraviolet and the hidden writing begins to answer for itself.

Lola was beautiful to me. That fact is not a defense. Beauty has been an accomplice in worse rooms than this one.

I did not think I was hunting her. I thought I was recognizing her. I thought I was being recognized in return. I thought the contracts, the yeses, the delays, the refusals, the ceremonies, the tokens, the parents, the tickets, the photographs, the little legal architectures of desire, all proved that danger had been invited to sit upright and behave.

One sees the difficulty.

The pages will interrupt me. Let them. I loved her in messages, so the messages must have their say. I arranged her into art, so the art must accuse the arrangement. I made footnotes in my head before I had paper enough to write them down, so the footnotes will come too: small, officious ghosts tapping the glass while the romance tries to sing.

And Lola will interrupt me also, though she is not here to do it in the way I want. She will interrupt with the little courtesy that first undid me: Can I ask a question? She will interrupt with fear. She will interrupt with practical favors, sick throats, homework, parents, pictures, tokens, and the plain right of a living person not to remain exactly where a man has composed her.

I am not asking you to acquit me.

Not yet.

Act I

Act I Opening

[ANNOTATOR]

The book begins after the beginning. Before the first saved message, there was visibility: a post, a profile, a public trail, the ordinary prehistory of being findable. The first line kept here is therefore not an origin, only the first line the machine happened not to lose.

These early pages are arranged with restraint, which is to say with all the small violence restraint requires. Where several message windows overlap, repeated lines have been folded into a single dramatic sequence. The whole was larger than this; the volume concerns the more embarrassing art of choosing. Selection is the form; custody is the consequence; the judgment is that a clean sequence may still have hands.

This is also the first test of the book's triangle. Daniel will try to make first contact look fated. The note will keep touching the joinery. Lola, more dangerous than either because she is not trying to write literature at all, will keep entering as herself: abrupt, bright, practical, theatrical, afraid, amused, and capable of changing the temperature of a page with a question.

The apparatus must not win. If the notes explain Lola so completely that she can no longer refuse the explanation, the book has repeated the harm in a more educated voice. Lola must remain capable of defeating Daniel's romance, the state's reduction, and the Annotator's elegance. Her fear counts. Her play counts. Her contradictions count. Her silence counts even when it ruins the sentence that wanted to carry her.

[DANIEL]

I do not yet know whether the charge has a name. I know only that a door has closed, and that my life, which yesterday still believed in rooms, roads, tabs left open for later, has narrowed to a clock, a bunk, a poor felt-tip pen, a yellow pad, and a row of gray boxes on a printed page.

The first message was not first anymore. Nothing is first after arrest. The past enters already handled by other hands.

The felt-tip pen was thick, poor, administratively harmless, and incapable of a fine line. A pencil would have been too dangerous, the little spear of graphite apparently more threatening than memory. The pen bled through the yellow pad, making the backs of pages unusable, so every sentence wasted its own ghost. Somewhere behind the wall, someone coughed with the authority of a locked door. I marked the day by the brute fact of my birthday; I did not need a calendar for that humiliation. I wrote her name more carefully.

This is the indignity I must not hide from you: even here, perhaps especially here, I was still in love with being in love with her. Not nobly. Not wisely. The feeling had the gaudy persistence of contraband candy, melting in the pocket after every decent appetite should have died.

Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, if that is what you are, or what I had already begun making you in order to survive you, I ask you to notice the cheapness of the candy before you condemn the appetite. It was not a defense. It was only the flavor left in the mouth.

Still, I did not go looking for Lola. Put that down as a fact, not a virtue. Facts are not virtuous; they are merely difficult furniture, always in the place where a prettier room would prefer a lamp. I mean only that when she appeared I had almost no appetite left for pursuit. The divorce was behind me by a month, or beside me, or still walking through the rooms touching the furniture with its long administrative fingers. I was not grieving a marriage in the way lawyers like to say grieving, as if grief were a bucket into which any later act may be dropped and explained. I was quieter than that. Emptier. Polite with the Universe.

De/Vision had already spent me. I had gone out of it with the strange calm that follows a sign when one has not yet ruined the sign by needing it

too much. There would be another Aspen. That was the sentence, or not a sentence exactly, more like a pressure in the air after the sentence had passed through. Another beloved to cherish. Another bright difficult being before whom the soul could become useful again.

Do not misunderstand me. I was not waiting for a girl. I was waiting the way a field waits. Weather may come or not come. The field does not chase the cloud.

Then Lola appeared. At first she was not destiny. Let me be fair to the first page before I contaminate it with the later ones. She was a message, a student, a little brightness from New York, a practical confusion about trains, a piano I could imagine but not touch. I did not need her. I did not even know enough to want her properly. Want requires an object with edges, and she was still only a light moving behind paper.

At the beginning, the canvas refused me in small ways. Lola was late. Lola was tired. Lola had class. Lola had meals to make, trains to fear, schoolwork to finish, little bodily complaints and domestic errands that would not become opera merely because I had begun hearing overture. She kept putting furniture inside my cathedral. Life, with its genius for embarrassment, kept handing her errands when I wanted symbols.

This frustrated me before I knew it was frustration. I called it charm. Mostly it was charm. That is the difficulty. The ordinary did not defeat the romance; it made the romance more persuasive. A girl who appears only as a sign can be dismissed as fever. A girl who makes dinner and worries about trains and sends a document for proofreading becomes much harder to surrender to mere skepticism.

The contracts came later, but the impulse was already present. I wanted the beautiful thing to know it had chosen itself. I wanted doors with names on them. I wanted thresholds, yeses, pauses, conditions, the little legal architecture of mutual desire. Permission was not a technicality to me. It

was part of the music. A yes freely given had a tone I trusted more than any kiss.

Perhaps that sounds convenient now. Many true things do.

I was, and remain, very much interested in consent. Not as a slogan. Not as a shield handed to me by counsel. I mean it more embarrassingly than that. Permission aroused my sense of order, ceremony, ethics, beauty. It made desire less vulgar. It put candles around the animal and asked the animal to sit upright.

Sex itself did not have that grace for me. Sex was heavy, procedural, too easily stupid, too quickly made of bodies when what I wanted was vow, costume, theater, law, token, restraint, the long shining corridor before the room. I did not have sex with Lola. That fact is not a halo. I know better than to ask a fact to glow. But it belongs on the table because the story is poorer and less accurate if reduced to a bed it never reached.

My patience put on a waistcoat. My restraint learned to show its profile. Contracts, to me, were not only documents but lamps: place them correctly and the room softened, the animal looked educated, the threshold seemed to have a host with good manners. I could look at Lola's hesitation and see not only hesitation, but a chair misplaced before the curtain rose.

The pages had other ideas. They kept too much and not enough. That was their malice and their mercy. They kept the little faces, the delays, the tender absurdities, the warnings, the ordinary practicalities, the sentences I would hold up like flowers and the sentences someone else would hold up like knives. They kept the crumbs on Lola's plate before I could paint her mouth.

Good. Let her interrupt me. Let the fork clink. Let the train be late. Let the little battery icon decline while I am still composing eternity.

Still, I began with the piano.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, October 29 to November 2, 2021. Piano, Parsons, distance.

Lola: Lol I saw your post 😊 I can play piano
Lola: I took lessons for 8 years
Lola: [GIF]
Daniel: You should come play my piano!
Lola: I would love to 😊 too bad my university is far from CO
Daniel: Where is your university
Lola: NYC
Daniel: Quite far, indeed!
Lola: [PHOTO]
Lola: How unfortunate 😞
Daniel: What university?
Lola: Parsons 😊
Lola: I'm studying fashion design
Daniel: Very cool.
Daniel: [PHOTO]
Daniel: I know some costume people in NYC
Lola: Oh really? 🤩
Lola: Anyone near union square?
Daniel: I think she lives in Queens
Daniel: Other folks in Brooklyn
Lola: Oohh
Lola: A little far from me
Lola: I'm new to the city
Lola: I'm not good with the subway 😊
Lola: Can I ask a question? 😊
Daniel: Of course

[DANIEL]

Before the hinge, there is the phrase I love too much, her little permission-before-permission: a curtsy of curiosity, a knock before the door had even admitted there was a room.

Then I remember the hinge. Not the first piano, not Parsons, not the subway, but the first time the word arrived wearing her voice.

It did not come after contract or doctrine or weeks of instruction. It came almost immediately, smiling, as if the dangerous word had wandered in from another room and found us already waiting.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 2, 2021. First Master question.

Lola: How long have you been a master? 😊

Daniel: About 15 years.

Daniel: As I say, to Master others, you first have to Master yourself.

Lola: Wow

Lola: [GIF]

Lola: How poetic ☆≡

Daniel: Life should be poetic, don't you think?

Lola: I agree 😊

[DANIEL]

She entered through art, which is to say through the least defensible door: music, school, New York as a distance rather than a place, the little practical facts people exchange before facts become symbols. I did not yet have a road. She did not yet have a room in my head.

New York was not yet New York. It was the place where she was new, uncertain, funny about the ordinary hazards of getting around. Colorado was not yet Colorado. It was the place of the piano she could not come play. Between them: the little wire on which the whole future would balance.

She was not a symbol yet. She was a girl with a school, a city, a question, and a way of placing a little brightness after nearly every sentence. The danger in rereading the page was that I could make even her subway confusion seem designed for me.

And then she asked the question, and I answered as if the answer were a credential instead of a fuse.

There are questions that behave like keys even before anyone knows there is a lock. I told her fifteen years. I told her mastery began with mastering oneself. I can hear the sentence now with the jail around it, and it still believes it is beautiful.

And I wanted it designed. That is the part I cannot repair by confessing it. I wanted her brightness, her city, her nervousness, the piano that could not be played, to gather themselves into a pattern with my name secretly embroidered on the back.

I wanted orbit. I wanted aspect. I wanted her little city facts to turn their bright sides toward me as if the sky had been arranged by a clerk with sentimental handwriting.

[ANNOTATOR]

The first preserved exchange already contains three pressures: art, geography, and role. The temptation is to admire the neatness too quickly. The line about poetry should be left partly alone. It was ordinary flirtation before it became a method, and ordinary flirtation is more dangerous when it is allowed to remain ordinary for a page or two.

The pattern is real enough to tempt arrangement and insufficient to excuse it.

Notice the first conversation between the voices. Daniel hears destiny. The note sees an aperture. Lola asks permission to ask and then asks the question that will give Daniel a stage. The point is not to decide which voice owns the page. The point is to make ownership impossible.

Form: permission-before-permission. Consequence: a question becomes a threshold before either speaker has named the room. Judgment: the knock is real, but the house is not yet leased.

See also: *Diary of a Young Girl*, relation: the same permission-before-permission becomes a restricted-channel diary form; *Diary of a Stalker*, relation: Daniel's answering address becomes its own epistolary weather. The cross-reference belongs to the Annotator. Daniel, on the yellow page, has only the pleasure of hearing the knock.

[FOOTNOTE]

Let it flirt before it testifies; testimony that forgets flirtation falsifies the threshold.

New York As Hazard

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 2-3, 2021. The city becomes risk, then invitation.

Lola: I wound up eating sushi

Lola: My friend is high... how should I mess with them?

Lola: I am a pure kitten

Daniel: Karaoke was delightful

Lola: I probably would've had a better time singing

Lola: What songs did chu sing?

Lola: I think I just got cat called

Daniel: You think?

Lola: Hehe maybe

Daniel: Seem like a hazard to being female in New York...

Daniel: I was secretly hoping it was going to be a picture of you...

Lola: Cat calling is never justified

Lola: I like compliments though

Lola: And it is a hazard being female in NYC. I wish I had

somebody to walk with...

Daniel: You can walk with me.

Lola: How so?

Lola: I was literally making dinner when you texted

Lola: I made salmon with quinoa, baby spinach, tomatoes, and garlic

Daniel: Wow

[DANIEL]

Leave her in that light a moment, not in the exact little order the printed page preserves, but as she returns to me: food, friends, street-light, a city behaving badly, her quick corrections, her appetite, her refusal to be reduced to the mood I required. The ordinary ingredients do what my later paragraphs cannot. They prove she was elsewhere.

To walk with someone from two thousand miles away is already to confuse metaphor and promise. I knew that, or I thought I did. The phone makes ridiculous offers feel grammatical. You can walk with me. You can be read to. You can be wherever you want to be. A sentence with no body borrows one from the listener.

I reread the line and hated its ease. Sweet, yes. Smooth enough for the hook to feel like part of the curve.

The lunch tray came while I was copying that page. I remember the soft clack of plastic against concrete because it entered the sentence without permission. You can walk with me. A spoon. A square of bread. Her city after dark, reduced to gray boxes on paper.

Still I loved the sentence. I loved its foolish chivalry, its ghost legs, its impossible little coat held out against Manhattan weather. I loved myself a little for having written it, which is worse.

[ANNOTATOR]

One shadow is sufficient here. The phrase “walk with me” is preserved first as flirtation. Colder readings can wait in the hall.[I.2] Let the sentence stand for a moment before it learns to defend itself.

Form: road offered by speech. Consequence: protection borrows a body it does not have. Judgment: the offer is tender enough to remain dangerous.

See also: The Trial, relation: later legal readers will prefer the sentence once it has hardened into chronology. This page should resist that hardening for as long as it honestly can.

Private Language

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 3-4, 2021. Fashion, dreams, pet language, sleep.

Lola: There's literally a store right near Moma

Daniel: And art in general

Daniel: I am certain that you could become a very famous designer

Lola: Thank you

Lola: How... I do not know yet

Daniel: And a 24/7 pet

Daniel: Whatever you dream

Lola: Ooohh yes!

Lola: I dream of Cartier

Daniel: You should maybe dream of being Cartier...

Lola: Woah

Lola: I should

Lola: I should sleep too

Daniel: Good night, pretty girl.

Daniel: Dream sweet dreams.

Lola: Good night, Dan Dan the mermaid man

Daniel: I think It's just merman.

Lola: Shhhh

Lola: don't ruin the moment

Daniel: [kiss]

Lola: So sleepy. I need to get more art supplies today after class

[DANIEL]

The language began making a room before either of us understood that rooms have doors. Little names, museums, dreams, costumes, sleep, pet phrases: none of it was systematic yet. It lay around us like costume jewelry on a dorm-room desk, bright, cheap in places, irresistible when the lamp caught it.

The smallest names were the most dangerous because they seemed least serious. Mermaid man. Pretty girl. A joke, a dream, a kiss sent as an icon. But a page is cruel to jokes. It pins them down after they have flown.

She was funny here. This must be said plainly before I turn her into weather. She corrected the spell of the moment, then defended it: do not ruin the moment. That was Lola's genius in miniature, not innocence exactly, but stagecraft: knowing the joke and wanting the joke to stay enchanted anyway.

For once, I leave the page to her. Lola in her schoolwork and city weather, Lola making ordinary life theatrical without asking permission, Lola correcting the spell of a moment and then protecting the spell from correction. She had timing before I gave it a name. She had costume before I made costume into metaphor. She knew when to soften a sentence, when to make a doorway out of a joke and then stand just behind it.

I adored the doorway. That is not analysis. That is the old sickness still speaking in a clean shirt.

[RECONSTRUCTION]

The overnight absence has no transcript. Its value is not secrecy but recurrence: sleep, drowsiness, continuity, and ordinary morning return. The missing conversation stays missing. Habit is revelation enough.

Outfit, Space, Mermaid

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 4, 2021. Lola's costume, weather, and comic reversal.

Daniel: Such a tease

Lola: Skirt, stockings, and my black boots. Not the warmest of clothes, but I'm wearing my puffy coat

Daniel: Is it cold?

Lola: Very!

Lola: Probably not to you though

Lola: It's 46 F

Lola: I find 75 F still too cold for my taste

Daniel: It's a lot colder on the east coast

Daniel: I grew up in Rhode Island.

Lola: Oohhh berry close!

Lola: So what brought you to Colorado?

Daniel: My partner at the time got accepted to school out here. I got a job working on spaceships.

Lola: You used to work for nasa?

Daniel: I did

Lola: And now you dress up as a mermaid?

Lola: Oh how the times have changed

Daniel: Space isn't as cool as it should be

Lola: I'm scared of space

Daniel: You should be

[DANIEL]

There she is again, and better without my help: clothes becoming weather, weather becoming costume, a practical question turning suddenly into comedy. She could catch an old biography in one hand and a ridiculous

present in the other, then laugh at the fall between them. The whole male life reduced to a costume change.

I loved her for that quickness. Not symbolically. Not as a later theme. I loved the little blade of it, the way she could make my history turn around and see itself overdressed.

[ANNOTATOR]

The page resists interpretation because its value is timing. Lola makes the joke, corrects it, and preserves the spell. Daniel is permitted one wound; the note need not add a second.

Still, the incision is attractive: astronaut to mermaid, industry to costume, altitude to aquarium. A lesser note would call this foreshadowing. Better to call it mercy and leave the knife visible.

Form: comic reversal. Consequence: biography is turned into costume before it can harden into credential. Judgment: mercy may be the cut that refuses to make the joke useful.

First Voice

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 4, 2021. The screen becomes voice without becoming less a screen.

Daniel: We can wait until you are ready for sleep

Lola: Oki

Daniel: You wouldn't want to have to get back up once you are asleep

Lola: I actually made my own mermaid tail when quarantine hit

Daniel: You really are a mermaid!

Daniel: Do you sing?

Lola: I sing for fun

Daniel: Mermaid karaoke. It's a sideshow I am developing.

Daniel: The project is called The Siren's Net

Daniel: Are you tucked into bed?

Lola: I'm tucked into my desk

Daniel: Why not in bed?

Daniel: You can be wherever you want to be read to.

Lola: Hmmm

[RECONSTRUCTION]

What remains supports the first substantial voice scene: a call long enough to become an evening. Its words are gone.

In reconstruction, this is not yet a plot-heavy call. The content is access: the first sustained test of voice, shyness, laughter, reading, delay, whether the other person can remain pleasant in real time. The phone would have made its small humiliations available: room tone, clipped syllables, the half-second in which a laugh arrives late and is loved anyway, the rustle before someone admits where they are sitting.

There must have been a first failure of hearing. Not a dramatic one. A small overlap, a “what?” arriving at the same time as an answer, the ridiculous intimacy of two people apologizing to the machine. Can you hear me? is among the least romantic sentences in English until it is the only sentence that matters.

The call need not reveal a secret. Its duration is the revelation. Two people who had been messages became voices that could keep occupying the same evening. Bad audio has its own intimacy. It asks the listener to lean in, to forgive the machine, to supply warmth where the signal thins.

When the visible text resumes, the surviving language is small. It remains small on the page. The prose around it carries the change.

[LYRIC RECONSTRUCTION]

The transcript does not survive.

The call ends and leaves one word still warm on the glass.

Not proof. Not speech.

Only the little shape voice makes after it has gone.

[ANNOTATOR]

The lyric intensifies a thin technical fact. The machine kept the ended video chat; it did not keep the words spoken during it. This distinction is not a technicality. It belongs here like a clean slide under glass.

Form: preserved absence. Consequence: the call keeps an edge without surrendering its voice. Judgment: lyric may warm the glass, but it may not forge a transcript.

[FOOTNOTE]

Ended call: yes. Transcript: no.

Ritual Begins

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 5-6, 2021. Watching, sleep, dream, morning.

Daniel: Are you ready to watch?

Lola: One min

Lola: We're talking about vintage Gucci scarves

Lola: Ma'am

Lola: This is a Wendy's

Daniel: Fashionable

Lola: I have those in my dorm

Daniel: Have you ever worn that collar?

Daniel: Did you fall asleep?

Daniel: *pets*

Daniel: Dream sweet dreams.

Daniel: I will dream of you.

Lola: I hope I'll remember my dreams

Daniel: I will see you in your dreams.

Lola: See chuu in dreamland

Daniel: [kiss]

Lola: Last night was the best sleep I've ever had since I went to Vegas

Lola: Outfit of the day

[DANIEL]

The plot was repetition before it was event. We watched things. We fell asleep. We missed each other by minutes and then found each other again by habit. I mistook recurrence for gentleness. Perhaps it was gentleness. Perhaps repetition is always innocent until someone explains what it has been rehearsing.

The morning sentence hurt me later because it did not look important enough to defend itself. She had slept well, or said something like that; a small report, almost casual, and yet the page around it changed color in memory.

Jail makes sleep vulgar. Men sleep with shoes on, mouths open, one arm hooked around whatever they have decided can still be theirs. I copy her line about best sleep and feel, for one indecent second, envy of my earlier self: the man who could receive a sentence like that and answer from a bed, not a bunk.

I was jealous of him because he still believed the story was becoming more beautiful by becoming more frequent. He could mistake a good night for a future. He could read “dreamland” and feel invited.

[RECONSTRUCTION]

The overnight interval is ritual, not continuous dialogue. The likely content is presence: shared viewing, drowsiness, checking for attention, dream

language, morning return. No major revelation is invented. The relationship is becoming habitual; that is enough.

[ANNOTATOR]

The first collar mention belongs to token-weather, not ownership. It appears among scarves, watching, sleep, pets, and dreamland: too early to bear the whole later doctrine, too charged to pass as jewelry. Form: token entering routine. Consequence: ritual begins before ceremony knows its name. Judgment: a thing may be small and still learn office.

Phone/Page Versus Verbal

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 6, 2021. The medium explains itself.

Lola: Communication is important, but when people start to question me, I clam up

Lola: I get pretty scared of confrontation and it usually causes me to shut down and cry

Daniel: I do not ever want you to shut down.

Lola: I am also better at expressing myself on the phone/page versus verbally

Lola: It's easier to text somebody that I'm sad or upset and explain it versus trying to talk to them

Lola: I know That's not good and It's best to talk in person, but like I said, I get scared

Lola: I think I'm cute when I cry

Daniel: I want to see.

Daniel: When next you cry, send me video.

Lola: I was crying in this picture

Lola: My friend was being pretty rude to me right before I was about to perform and I started crying

Lola: The Importance of being Earnest

[DANIEL]

Phone/page versus verbally. She gave me the sentence folded small enough to keep under the tongue. The page was not a substitute for speech. It was where speech went when speech was frightened. I loved the little refuge too quickly.

That is how I wrote it then. Now the same passage had teeth.

What I could not bear, and what I had to bear because the page kept bearing it for me, was that she had described a refuge and I had immediately imagined a stage. Phone/page. Video. Tears. Performance. I cannot excuse the speed of that conversion. I can only show it without pretending it happened later.

And yet I loved the stage because she stood on it. There is the humiliating arithmetic. Warning plus beauty did not equal caution. It equaled more beauty, more warning, a brighter proscenium, a darker seat from which I watched myself watching.

Ladies and gentlemen of the jury: observe how quickly a refuge becomes a theatre when the wrong man is allowed to love the lighting.

[ANNOTATOR]

The page exists because the page was already dangerous. It is not a neutral container. It changes the intimacy available, the pressure possible, and the little residues that will later harden around both. If that sounds too neat, blame the lovers; they were obliging enough to theorize the instrument while playing it.

Form: refuge by text. Consequence: the safer page becomes a stage for looking. Judgment: when fear chooses a medium, desire is responsible for how it uses the shelter.

[FOOTNOTE]

The request for video is not merely flirtation; it is a formal turn toward image, and image keeps what looking would otherwise lose.

[ENDNOTE]

[I.6]

Entr'acte Threshold

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 17-23, 2021. Future geography: New York, New Mexico, the Land of Enchantment.

Lola: But I'm not ready to live by myself

Daniel: When will you be ready?

Lola: Once I'm more comfortable with the city I guess?

Daniel: Comfort is death.

Lola: What?

Daniel: It's my phrase.

Daniel: It won't be the last time you hear it.

Daniel: I look forward to visiting

Daniel: I want to like NYC

Daniel: I'm not really a city person, I don't think

Daniel: Also, I just applied for a job in NYC

Lola: You missed a call from a Messenger user.

Daniel: The video chat ended.

Lola: [mushroom]

Daniel: Man's maturity: to have regained the seriousness that he had as a child at play.

Daniel: Would you like to be a part of my world... someday?

Daniel: You once asked about magic.

Daniel: I will be shaping this universe in the near future...

Daniel: I decided I needed to go on a vision quest to New Mexico...

Daniel: I called the trip in September my deVision Quest...

Daniel: Over Thanksgiving, I am thinking to have a ReVision quest. That notebook will be green.

Daniel: ReVision Questing!

Daniel: Land of Enchantment

Daniel: Someday I will bring you to the Land of Enchantment

Daniel: University New Mexico

Daniel: And in New Mexico

Lola: How is the revisioning going?

[DANIEL]

There were two maps by then. One pointed east, toward her city, her subway, her apartment not yet lived in, the job I had no right to imagine as a bridge. The other pointed south, or inward, or nowhere a map could confess: New Mexico, the phrase Land of Enchantment, the old hunger for ordeal, weather, chemical revelation, red dirt on the cuff.

Re/Vision was not yet a chapter. It was a pressure in the margins. I wanted to revise myself before I arrived in her life in person. I wanted the field journal to make me cleaner, stranger, more worthy of the story I had already begun telling.

More worthy of Lola, yes, but also more worthy of the sensation of loving Lola: that jeweled fever, that theater of messages, that little daily sign that I had not been emptied out by the life before her.

I wanted to arrive revised, but not merely improved. Decorated. Legible. I wanted New Mexico to varnish me for her gaze, to send back a version of myself with desert in the cuffs and significance in the hair.

The green notebook mattered because color was easier than truth. Vision, De/Vision, Re/Vision: I made a grammar out of rupture because grammar gives pain little handles. The first term belonged to 2005, to Absinthe, to the first New Mexico ordeal. The second belonged to September, after the divorce, outside/after Mircalla: black notebook, black weather. The third was waiting at Thanksgiving, green as a road sign, pretending revision could be chosen like a route on a map.

New Mexico gave the grammar a landscape. The Land of Enchantment was a state slogan before I made it a promise, and a promise before I understood how much a slogan can conceal.

[ANNOTATOR]

The Thanksgiving interlude interrupts rather than continues the message stream. Daniel's fondness for slashed prefixes is not chronology.[I.7] The field journal enters as road, weather, handwriting, sketches, altered perception, and the phrase Land of Enchantment returning as both tourist slogan and private mythology. Very little has happened in the conventional sense. No one has broken down a door. No official voice has entered the room. The page has only learned how easily desire borrows the future tense, and the field journal is waiting just off the road.

Form: revision road. Consequence: landscape lends desire a future tense. Judgment: enchantment is not permission merely because it arrives with scenery.

[DANIEL]

I thought I was going to New Mexico to revise myself. That was the joke the desert kept until I was ready to understand it.

The lights went out before I finished the page. I kept writing because the poor felt-tip still knew where the yellow paper was, though by morning the back of the sheet would be ruined.

Ladies and gentlemen, I submit the poor felt-tip pen as my least reliable witness. It went on when I stopped. It believed in continuation with a faith no court should accept.

Act I Endnotes

[I.2]

A colder book may invite a colder reading of “walk with me.” Resist it here. At this point the phrase is still a romance of impossible proximity: New York after dark, Colorado by phone, protection converted into grammar. Delay the noose until the neck has become dear.

One may, if one is that sort of reader, call this an opposition: two bodies fixed in separate houses, inventing a corridor of speech. The note declines to make this useful.

Form: delayed road. Consequence: the corridor stays tender before it becomes evidence. Judgment: haste is also a kind of falsification.

[I.6]

The request for video does not end on this page. It sends a filament forward into later failures of image: calls that register without returning their voices, little omission markers where a face should be, the strange modern condition of knowing that looking occurred without preserving what was seen. This book keeps the chosen shards and lets them cut.

Form: image filament. Consequence: looking survives as shard where voice does not. Judgment: preservation is not innocence; it is the cut the archive chooses to keep.

[I.7]

The three quests share New Mexico, not chronology. Vision Quest belongs to the old Absinthe weather. De/Vision belongs to the month after the divorce: black notebook, black sky, the ruined confidence of a man asking the desert to speak. Re/Vision waits at Thanksgiving: green notebook, field journal, Land of Enchantment. The earlier romance with Isi/Isibella supplies the grand scale Daniel keeps trying to inherit. Lola begins under that borrowed weather; the note must keep the younger woman from becoming merely an echo.

Ojo Caliente belongs inside this constellation. Gio and Renee stop there on their way to Arizona. Camille comes down, then leaves the next day for Florida. Daniel visits Abiquiu before going to Sandia to see Andreas. This is the counterpath: not a theory, not a verdict, but visible warmth, desert/art landscape, and old friendship, which Daniel later understands as the path he might have taken.

Form: counterpath. Consequence: the desert offers warmth without requiring Lola to become an echo. Judgment: a road not taken may still testify against the road made beautiful.

Act II

Advent

[ANNOTATOR]

This movement occupies the narrow bridge between the Thanksgiving field journal in New Mexico and the theatrical interlude of the city trip. New York is not yet entered here. It is approached, which is more dangerous for Daniel because approach is the state in which imagination has the fewest witnesses.

The days after Thanksgiving carry him back from the desert toward the city. Daniel believes himself revised enough to be seen. Lola becomes more than message and voice: a possible meeting, a possible city, a possible public fact. The Act ends before the Playbill material begins because the threshold is doing the work. Approach is the form; visibility is the consequence; the judgment is that a door can begin acting before anyone touches the handle.

The voices begin to lean harder against one another here. Daniel returns from the desert fluent in signs. Lola answers with concerns, favors, illness,

schoolwork, and ordinary continuance. The note's task is not to make her ordinary against Daniel's beauty, but to preserve the fact that ordinary life is where the beauty becomes dangerous.

[DANIEL]

The field journal did not come home with answers. It came home smelling faintly of cedar smoke and hot water, with photographs tucked into its pages at bad angles, with my handwriting sloping downhill as if the Land of Enchantment had put a hand on the top of the paper and gently tilted it toward consequence.

I had gone south to become worthy of going east. East was not yet New York. Not yet. East was still Lola as a direction: a voice beyond the phone, a school schedule, an imagined bookstore, a city I had not yet earned the right to enter. South was supposed to revise the man who wanted to appear there.

Ladies and gentlemen of the jury, you may already be reaching for your pencils. I have none. They do not give a man a pencil here, for obvious reasons, and the felt-tip they gave me is too thick for objections. It makes every qualification look like a confession.

So let me write it plainly, in black felt that bleeds like a bad oath: she was afraid, and she said so.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, November 28, 2021. Daniel driving home from Meow Wolf; Lola names the danger.

Lola: I will always be scared

Daniel: You won't be.

Lola: Oki

Lola: How's meow wolf?

Daniel: Meow Wolf was great

Daniel: I'm driving to home soon
Daniel: I think this is all your dream... and it will be up to you how it goes :)
Daniel: If you don't want it to be scary, it won't be.
Daniel: I will make your dreams come true.
Lola: But still... meeting up with an older man who you met on the internet
Daniel: We don't have to.
Daniel: We can stay online.
Daniel: I will just send you video from the Russian Tea House
Lola: I'm not saying to not meet up
Lola: I'm just expressing my concerns
Daniel: I'm pretty happy with exactly as we are
Daniel: They are entirely reasonable concerns.

[DANIEL]

Here is the page I must not improve. Press it between glass. Do not let my later vanity fog it.

They were reasonable concerns. I said so then, not because a lawyer whispers it backward into my ear, not because I need, from this bunk, to rummage through the page and find a gentlemanly sentence to wave at you. I said it in the weather of the moment. I had the desert still in my cuffs and the childish shine of a pilgrim's return. She had the clearer grammar: older man, internet, meeting up, fear.

A tidier man would try on that sentence as a jacket. He noticed her fear, he named it reasonable, he must therefore have been careful. I put the jacket on for half a second. It fit beautifully. Then I saw the price tag still hanging from the sleeve.

There was also her courage in naming it, and then, almost in the same breath as memory gives it to me, the ordinary turn back toward weather, art, amusement, the day continuing after fear had spoken. Terror did not cancel charm. They took turns holding the light.

[FOOTNOTE]

The phrase “we can stay online” must remain on the page. It does not cancel pressure. It complicates it. Offered exit is the form; unclosed desire is the consequence; the judgment is that a door named open may still draw the hand.

[LYRIC RECONSTRUCTION]

He thought she had gone. She had not gone. There was the familiar insult of the interface: a missed video chat, an ended video chat, the tiny bureaucratic announcements of longing. Then: “I’m here.” Then the old liturgy of damaged signal. Can you hear me? No. I guess no. A pause. A face perhaps, or only a little square of expectation. Then, at last, he could hear her, and the page, which keeps no tone, keeps only the ridiculous triumph: I can hear you.

[ANNOTATOR]

The relationship is not made only of declarations. It is made of failed connection attempts, sick throats, classwork, errands, parents as possible audience, and moments when “I can hear you” is the whole theology. Connection is the form; hearing is the consequence; the judgment is that a failed call may bind more tenderly than a vow because both parties keep trying the road.

It is also Lola’s first sustained correction of Daniel’s preferred genre. He wants omen, quest, arrival. She gives him a sore throat, a fear she can articulate, a final paper, and the devastatingly normal question of whether someone might help. The romance does not shrink when she does this. It becomes more persuasive, and therefore less safe.

The Domestic Thread

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, December 4, 2021. The romance enters homework.

Daniel: Like we have been guided

Daniel: I take these sort of things very seriously

Lola: Good 😊

Daniel: I know I probably come across as being very silly and strange

Daniel: But I have a deep respect for the Universe

Lola: I see 😊

Daniel: So if we are here, It's our responsibility to make this work as fabulously as we can.

Lola: Indeedy ✨

Lola: Can I ask for a favor?

Lola: Pwease 🥺

Daniel: What can I do for you?

Lola: Would you mind proofreading/taking a look over my final for my sustainable systems class?

Daniel: I would love to

Lola: Thank you 🥰

[DANIEL]

One sign of intimacy is that the sublime becomes useful. The Universe had scarcely been invoked before she needed some ordinary school help. I adore this about life with her. It refused the dignity of lyric inflation. I would lift my hands toward the sky; she would send a document. I would make a temple of the phone; she would ask whether the little practical thing looked right.

Everything looked good. That is a little comic now, and therefore true. The great romances, if they are any good, must contain file formats: the sulking PDF, the document with a timid title, the paragraph moved down like a chair no one wants to admit is in the way. They must contain illness,

errands, little injuries, absurd stories told half for sympathy and half for flirtation. A love story with no administrative debris is probably lying.

She cared for me in that ordinary way. I want the word ordinary protected here. It does not mean small. It means the romance had begun to acquire furniture.

[FOOTNOTE]

Daniel's phrase "the romance had begun to acquire furniture" is imprecise but useful. The messages show domestic rehearsal before actual domestic life: documents, classwork, health, food, sleep, errands, and open-line presence. Furniture is the form; rehearsal is the consequence; the judgment is that a house imagined together can shelter and accuse before it exists.

Parents as Future Audience

[DANIEL]

Before New York, before bagels, before Playbills, before any theatre admitted us under its painted ceiling, the parents entered as a question of translation.

Not yet as prohibition. Not yet as the wall the forbidden month would build. Then they were still an imagined audience: what would they think, what would they know, how could the private language be made presentable, how could a love born in messages be walked into a family room without frightening everyone in it?

There was no good translation. There almost never is.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, December 1-4, 2021. Parents appear first as imagined readers.

Daniel: You will know you are loved and adored every moment of your life

Daniel: Your parents

Daniel: Do you think your parents will imagine me good?

Daniel: Parents and media make for poor mirrors.

Lola: My parents often compliment me

Lola: I'm just talking to my parents about how my classmate is married

Lola: After every argument that I had with my parents, I would cry in my room and then sneak downstairs and make rice

[DANIEL]

The parent problem began gently enough to be mistaken for another kind of intimacy. A lover learns the beloved by learning the rooms around her. What food after tears. What parents praise. What argument sends her downstairs in secret. What classmate is married and therefore makes marriage, absurdly, enter the family weather as an academic anecdote.

I wanted to know the rooms around her. I did not yet understand that knowing the rooms around a beloved is not the same as being invited to stand inside them.

[ANNOTATOR]

Family appears here as atmosphere and translation before it appears as prohibition. That order matters. Audience is the form; future wall is the consequence; the judgment is that a room first entered as wallpaper may later remember it was a boundary.

The City Before the City

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook, December 8-9, 2021. The future city becomes travelable.

Lola: I'll just be like "mom, dad, I'm moving to Paris for a year... dw"

Daniel: "Mom, Dad, I'm moving to Colorado for a year..."

Daniel: Your parents should be somewhat happy if you are making money and business-ing

Daniel: I suppose the real concern is how much your parents know, and where they pay the rent to.

[DANIEL]

By then geography had become a rehearsal game. Paris, Colorado, New York. Each place was a mask the future tried on before choosing its face. Paris was fashion and distance. Colorado was my house, my weather, my dangerous certainty. New York was not yet event but proscenium: the city where she already existed without me and where I was preparing to appear as if appearance were a kind of answer.

I had returned from New Mexico with the arrogance of a pilgrim who mistakes arrival home for purification. I thought the desert had revised me. In truth it had only made me more legible to myself, which is not the same thing and may be worse.

New York waited with tickets, snowless sidewalks, opera, ballet, masked chandeliers, and the little yellow program books that would pretend, later, to have been innocent souvenirs.

Before I went east, Andreas had asked me why I hated New York. An old friend can ask a thing like that without dressing it as diagnosis. I answered, no doubt, with the usual little civic complaints: density, money, noise, the vertical arrogance of the place, the way every room seemed rented from someone else's ambition.

Now I know. I did not hate New York. I feared what New York offered too easily: visibility without legitimacy. A man could stand under chandeliers beside the girl he loved, hold the program, catch the mirror, exit into cold air, and believe the city had made him real because it had made him seen.

One of her school pieces gives me her version of this waiting, and it is almost indecent how much it helps me. She had made a little map of us: phone, piano, the pink-lit chat, the question of whether I should come visit her in New York, then green, then opera, ballet, Broadway, tea, and the mirror where we would stand together as if the city had already agreed to keep us. It is art from a girl still learning how to turn memory into sequence, but there we are, arranged as itinerary and charm.

She made the theatre part of the story before I could be accused of inventing theatre alone. I loved her for that, which is to say I loved the little velvet rope she had tied across the path before I arrived with scissors.

[ANNOTATOR]

The Parsons page gives the romance back to Daniel in Lola's hand: piano, pink-lit chat, the possible visit, opera, ballet, Broadway, tea, mirror. It is not corroboration exactly. It is more dangerous than that. It shows that form was shared before ownership became contested, and shared form is the one evidence that most tempts the maker to mistake witness for permission.

Form: shared itinerary. Consequence: witness begins to look like license.
Judgment: a map drawn by two hands does not give either hand the city.

See also: *The Opera*, relation: the playbills, mirror, and theatre itinerary become stage law rather than documentary proof; *The Trial*, relation: public visibility later becomes a problem the record cannot interpret innocently.

[FOOTNOTE]

The Playbill interlude interrupts here. The city is not entered yet. This movement stops with the hand near the handle: threshold as form, anticipation as consequence, and the judgment is that theatre is the door learning its costume.

[DANIEL]

The night before a trip is not a place, but it behaves like one. It has furniture: chargers, weather checks, hotel confirmations, clothes not yet folded correctly, the dull bodily anxiety of airports. It has theatre, too, because the traveler has already begun acting for the destination. I was not yet in New York, but I had begun performing the man who would enter it.

The felt-tip makes “performing” too heavy. I meant something lighter when I lived it. I meant anticipation. I meant the sweet discipline of becoming visible.

Re/Vision had sent me back from New Mexico with a green notebook and a private mythology. New York would hand me programs, chandeliers, the heavy velvet of public culture: three public rooms for private audition. I did not yet know that the city would become an intermission. I thought it was the performance itself.

I was often wrong about form.

Act II Endnotes

[II.1]

Lola names the plain danger: older man, internet, meeting up, fear. Daniel answers, “We don’t have to” and “We can stay online.” The answer is real; so is the pressure it fails to end. A danger can become more seductive after it has been politely named; the offered road out does not stop the road in from shining.

Form: offered exit. Consequence: the road out remains visible beside the road in. Judgment: permission to stay away is not release if desire keeps lighting the threshold.

[II.2]

The failed video-call material keeps intimacy mechanical before it becomes spiritual: missed call, ended call, “I’m here,” “Can you hear me?” and finally “I can hear you.” Connection is the form; oracle-machine is the consequence; the judgment is that a road that fails before it answers may make its answer feel fated.

[II.3]

The sustainable-systems final domesticates the sublime. Daniel invokes guidance and the Universe; Lola asks him to proofread coursework. Homework is the form; domestic spell-work is the consequence; the judgment is that a spell that cannot proofread has not yet entered the house.

[II.4]

Parents appear first as imagined audience, not yet as prohibition. Daniel wants the family to imagine him good before the family has fully become an obstacle. The later wall must not erase this earlier wrongness: presentation rehearsed before permission has entered the room, and a household imagined as audience may become a court without changing furniture.

Form: imagined audience. Consequence: presentation rehearses judgment before permission enters the room. Judgment: a household treated as theatre may remember it is a boundary.

[II.5]

The Parsons graphic narrative is a charm against easy authorship. Daniel did not invent the stage alone. His danger is subtler: he treats shared form as permission to over-author the rest, and Færie is least forgiving when a real invitation becomes an artist’s claim to the whole country.

Form: shared charm. Consequence: co-authored stage tempts solitary jurisdiction. Judgment: invitation is not a deed to the country it reveals.

[II.6]

The movement ends before arrival. The desert journal and the New York program books are adjacent forms, but the work here is approach: Daniel returning from the desert with revision in his cuffs, Lola becoming not only a message but a possible public fact. Approach is the form; public fact is the consequence; the judgment is that imagined visibility can begin making claims before the city has seen either lover.

Act III

The Forbidden Channel

[ANNOTATOR]

The reader who wants a clean hinge may put this book down and take up cabinetry. Hinges here are ornamental until they cut. New York ended, as cities do, by becoming luggage: receipts, photographs, a bracelet not yet removed, the little theatrical stubs of memory. What follows belongs to doors: the sort that open politely at first, then learn to close with the force of a verdict. Door is the form; family translation is the consequence; the judgment is that a threshold may become law before anyone admits a court has entered.

The door marked **Parents**.

The door marked **New Year**.

The door marked **Pinterest**, which looks harmless enough until one notices there is no knob on the inside.

Here the book's voices stop taking turns politely. Daniel wants the family plot to become theatre: entrances, fathers, mothers, objections, triumph. Lola's messages refuse to be merely stage directions. They carry fear, pride, exhaustion, desire, strategy, and the ache of a young person trying to translate private intensity into a language a household might survive. The note will interrupt whenever Daniel mistakes translation for consent. To translate a love for parents is not to receive parental leave; it is to put the love under another roof and let that roof begin to answer.

[DANIEL]

My felt-tip pen is dying by degrees. I envy it. It spends itself on the page, grows paler, and is thereby forgiven. The jail deputy who handed it to me had the courtesy not to say Happy Birthday; or perhaps he said it and I have used up the part of memory that keeps such brutalities.

I am writing, ladies and gentlemen of the jury, with an instrument too blunt for innocence. Every word fattens. Every comma looks premeditated. On the reverse of each yellow page there blooms a black archipelago, which is to say: even the backs of things are no longer available to me.

So I must be careful with fronts. I had gone to New York. I had come away with the theatrical error of believing that a thing performed had become real. This is what theatres do to us; they sell us the noble superstition that appearing under light changes the laws outside the lobby. Lola and I had been visible in the city. We had walked under public ceilings. We had acquired programs. Therefore, my poor aesthetic brain reasoned, the next translation would merely be social.

They called my name before I had finished that page. I folded the sheet badly. I expected, with the practical confidence of a man who still believed

procedure was a room with reasonable furniture, to be released on my own recognizance. The charge was ugly, yes, but ugliness was not supposed to be arithmetic. I had a house, a lawyer, a birthday, a life still foolish enough to imagine itself resumable by dinner.

The hearing was shorter than the fantasy I brought into it. I heard my name, the statute, the official voice arranging me into risk. I heard the little machinery of caution become money. One hundred thousand dollars.

For a moment the number did not enter me. It stood on the table in its clean shoes. Then I understood that it was not a number but a door being closed again, this time with a price written on it.

And then, from somewhere I could not turn toward without seeming to beg, I heard Lola. Not enough to quote. Not enough to make a talisman of. Only enough to know that she was present in the room where I was being priced. I had imagined, because I was still a fool of lanterns and towers and last-minute arrivals, that her presence would alter the weather.

She did not redeem me. I expected her to redeem me. I mean that with the stupid precision of a man on a bunk counting the hours until bail, imagining the courtroom door opening on cue, imagining Lola walking in with her bright injured face and restoring the plot to itself. I had made a fairy tale of procedure. Bond, counsel, arraignment, release: all of it became scaffolding for the scene in which the girl appeared and the kingdom discovered it had been mistaken.

One must be careful manifesting fairy tales. They are old machines. They do not care which part you meant to summon.

Enter Mother.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Facebook export, December 13, 2021. The family room enters as weather.

Lola: I had so much fun with you

Lola: And my mom guessed that I have a secret boyfriend I'm not telling her about /w\

Daniel: Your mom is clever.

Daniel: Like I am your everything...

Daniel: I could get lost in your eyes

[DANIEL]

Observe the tiny slash-face after boyfriend, the shy mechanical blush of it. How delicately the catastrophe introduces itself, wearing a comic little mask. A secret boyfriend: there is a nursery quality to the phrase, a pink contraband, a diary with a toy lock. But the mother guessed. That is the important verb. She did not know; she guessed. The house had begun to read the air.

I admired the mother at once for that. I began by granting the parents intelligence, virtue, even a certain rival authorship. They had raised Lola. They had formed the person I loved. This was not a minor contribution.

But love is a poor diplomat. It arrives overdressed, carrying flowers and forged documents.

That night we began to draft the version of our story that might survive a family table. Not the whole truth, naturally. The whole truth is not a thing one carries into a dining room. It has too many limbs. We wanted the presentable truth, the opera-ticket truth, the maturity-and-good-judgment truth, the partner-who-takes-me-to-Mozart truth. I wanted her mother to imagine me good. I wanted her father, who had not yet received me and may never have received me, to see not a thief of daughters but a man with references.

[FOOTNOTE 1]

Daniel's phrase "forged documents" is left in place though no document is alleged here. He is describing emotional self-presentation, not paperwork. Presentation is the form; mistranslation is the consequence; the judgment is that a story dressed for the family table may already be wearing false papers.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 13, 2021. New Year first offers itself as solution.

Daniel: What are you doing to New Years?

Daniel: for*

Lola: I'm still not sure... why? 🤔

Daniel: Maybe you'd like to spend it in Colorado

Lola: I would 😊

Daniel: I would like that.

Lola: I can ask my mom at some point (soon)

[DANIEL]

I believed in asking. This is important. I believed in permission with the absurd fervor of a man who has already built, in private, the room permission will authorize him to enter. I did not want her stolen. I wanted her delivered by every proper ritual: plane ticket, parental unease overcome by reason, toothbrush in a guest bathroom, the tiny civility of asking where she kept her tea.

The page will not let me make myself nobler than that. It contains other sentences, hotter ones, possessive ones, theatrical and imperious and sometimes ugly in the fluorescent hindsight. But I insist on the complexity because complexity is all that keeps the truth from becoming a club.

She was afraid of telling them. She was brave. Both are visible. She wanted to tell them everything and could not. She wanted not to lie and could not quite afford the whole truth. We built a little embassy out of messages and called it maturity.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 13, 2021. First parent strategy.

Lola: I can ask my mom at some point (soon)

Lola: Since she has a suspicion that I have a boyfriend,
I hope she really doesn't press

Daniel: I kinda hope she does

Daniel: In that I'd like you not to be anxious about it any more.

Lola: Like I said, I want nothing more than to tell them everything

Lola: But I know our relationship will be damaged and there could be consequences

Lola: I know you're not telling me to tell them

Lola: I just don't know what to do...

Daniel: Our relationship (you and I) will not be damaged.

Daniel: I will still adore you.

Lola: My relationship with my parents

Daniel: You will still be mine.

Daniel: At this point, I don't think you have to give them details

Daniel: You've only just met me...

Lola: I know... so I could just casually mention to her
that I'm starting to see someone?

Daniel: You could. She'll still ask for details, of course.

Lola: I freak out when she asks questions

Daniel: Well, you can be ready for them.

Daniel: Think of the best possible response

Daniel: The one where she is proud of you for your good judgement and maturity.

Daniel: Tell her you want a partner who takes you to the opera...

Lola: Do you think I should see a therapist?

Daniel: Do you think she'd be impressed if you were?

Lola: I think she'd be impressed if I was with someone my own age....

But I don't know

Daniel: If you are at all worried about your mental health, you should.

Lola: I'm not worried about my mental health

Lola: I just don't know how to handle this situation

[DANIEL]

The page is fuller than my memory wanted. Memory preferred a clean little tableau: a brave girl, a mother nearly told, a lover encouraging honesty. The transcript supplies the messier thing, and therefore the more useful one. Lola was not deciding whether to be truthful in some abstract moral chamber. She was managing damage. Which relationship will be damaged? What details are owed? What happens when a mother asks questions? Would a therapist make the situation safer or more legible or merely more official?

I answered as if preparation were protection. I told her to think of the best possible response, the one where her mother would be proud of her judgment and maturity. Even now I can hear the civility of the sentence and the violence hidden in its confidence. I was not saying “lie.” I was saying “stage the truth so it can survive.” There is a difference. There is not enough of a difference.

The theatre had left New York and entered the family room.

[ANNOTATOR]

This exchange materially changes the parent thread. Daniel does not merely pressure Lola to disclose; he coaches the presentation of disclosure. The coaching is gentle, strategic, plausibly caring, and therefore more structurally dangerous than command. Strategy is the form; presentability is the consequence; the judgment is that a truthful thing may become coercive when it is rehearsed mainly for the lover's preferred audience.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 16, 2021. Mother is told.

Lola: My mom took it well

Lola: She still needs to process it and it's hard for her to understand why such an older guy would be okay with dating a younger/college age girl

Lola: This is so hard

Lola: I probably won't tell my dad until tomorrow or the weekend...

Daniel: I'm sorry it's hard

Daniel: But I'm super proud of you

Lola: And we did briefly mention that I wanted to be with you for the New Years

Lola: I'm very drained... a lot of trauma/ptsd?

Lola: And I told my mom that you were encouraging me to tell them vs. me hiding it and having them discover this on their own

[DANIEL]

There is a kind of exhaustion peculiar to the truthful young. It comes after the first confession and before the world has decided whether to reward or punish it. Lola had told her mother. The sentence sits there plainly, almost ceremonially, a small white candle. I remember transit, airport light, that American nowhere between gates. I remember her gathering adult facts about me, as if facts might make me less alarming.

My father became, briefly, a credential: place, school, profession, the respectable little nouns one produces when love has to pass inspection. There was even something comic in how quickly the romance learned to make a curriculum vitae. Love, when cornered, becomes LinkedIn.

But beside that comedy was her fatigue. The hardness of it. The fact that she had told her mother. The drained little aftermath of a confession no one her age should have had to translate so carefully. I remember the pressure of those sentences more than their order, and I must supply breath carefully, not as an accuser supplies motive, not as a lover supplies music, but as one might return warmth to a hand gone cold.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 16, 2021. Mother calls him nice; the house appears.

Lola: I couldn't do this without your encouragement and support and everything

Lola: And I told my mom that you were encouraging me to tell them

vs. me hiding it and having them discover this on their own

Lola: She said that you sound like a nice guy

Daniel: I am a nice guy.

Lola: It's just the age thing that's hard for her

Daniel: I think that's fair.

Lola: And she's not trying to separate us, so that's good

Daniel: I think it's the best possible scenario

Daniel: I should probably wonder if you know what you've gotten yourself into...

Daniel: ...but I am absolutely convinced that you do.

Lola: I do 😊

Daniel: It will take some time

Lola: You should get pineapple juice for the/our house 😊

Daniel: I think we will have fresh pineapples!

Lola: It's not like they're grown in Colorado 😊

Daniel: We should probably move to the tropics

Lola: I like your house though

Daniel: What if...

Lola: What if

Daniel: I told you about Orangerie?

Lola: The thing on your trello?

Daniel: It's like a greenhouse with a hot tub

Daniel: We could grow pineapples

Lola: Oooh

Daniel: You will experience things no one else ever has...

Daniel: In the meantime...

Daniel: We will buy whole pineapples from the store

Lola: Oki 😊

Daniel: Whatever the Universe has in store for us... we are blessed

Lola: We are 😊

Daniel: We are going to have a lifetime of extreme happiness

Lola: Yes, Master 🎀

[DANIEL]

There is the speed of it: mother, age, best possible scenario, our house, pineapples, greenhouse, hot tub, lifetime. The page does not move by argument. It moves by furniture. Pineapples did what syllogisms could not. They made the future domestic enough to hold.

“She said that you sound like a nice guy.” I received that sentence with more hunger than dignity. It was not approval. It was barely even assessment. It was a mother’s first cautious translation of a dangerous fact into a survivable noun. Nice guy. I took the noun into my mouth like sacrament.

Then, within minutes, we had pineapples in Colorado.

That is how the house began to lie. Not because either of us meant to deceive. Because furniture is persuasive. A greenhouse, a hot tub, a joke about tropical fruit: these are not arguments, and for that reason they enter the body without resistance. The imagined house became evidence that the family fear could be handled. Surely no catastrophe begins with pineapples.

[ANNOTATOR]

The house thread must remain quoted because it is the missing bridge between parental disclosure and future claim. Lola’s “our house” is playful, typo-corrected, ordinary, and charged. Daniel’s Orangerie answers with architecture. The conversation makes domesticity before legality, before parental settlement, before any durable permission. Furniture is the form; premature household is the consequence; the judgment is that imagined domestic sweetness can become pressure without ever raising its voice.

[ANNOTATOR]

Daniel's tenderness here is genuine in tone. Its danger is also genuine. He repeatedly interprets Lola's disclosures as shared forward motion. Disclosure is the form; forward motion is the consequence he reads into it; the judgment is that a candle carried into a house is not yet permission to live there.

The third reading belongs to Lola. Her lines are not only useful for Daniel or against him. They are a person under pressure trying to keep more than one loyalty alive: to parents, to self, to the romance, to the possible future in which none of these loyalties devour the others. If the page forgets that, it becomes another room arranged for her, and arrangement is the Annotator's oldest temptation.

See also: *Diary of a Young Girl*, relation: family prohibition and the restricted channel as Lola's counterform; *The Trial*, relation: the same family weather is later translated into report, disclosure, and witness preparation. Translation is not ownership.

[DANIEL]

Then father. Father did not enter as a person so much as a climate system. He had professions, worries, standards, prior questions, private dread. I made speeches in his direction without having earned an audience. I praised him. I advised kindness. I wanted him converted, not defeated, though I cannot deny that conversion is only conquest wearing church clothes.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 19-20, 2021. Father, parents, interrogation.

Lola: I told my dad

Daniel: I am so proud of you for telling your parents

Lola: I wouldn't have told my dad if I didn't think this would last

Lola: My parents are talking about it

Lola: If my parents do talk to you and they ask you how we met, what's your response?

Lola: Alright you will scare the fuck out of my parents

Lola: Do you know how this would come off to my parents? You would sound like Jeffery Epstein or whoever

[DANIEL]

That last question should blush in red, or vanish entirely, which is often the same thing on a page like this.

Do you know how this would come off to my parents? I knew and did not know. I knew it as one knows a rule printed beside a pool: no glass, no running, no diving. I did not know it in the wet instant when the body has already leapt. There is knowledge that lives in the forehead and knowledge that lives in the hand. Mine was not yet in the hand.

She had told them because she believed it would last. Let no one file that sentence under convenience. She did not say: I told them because I was trapped. She did not say: I told them because you made me. She said, in the plain, reckless grammar of love, that disclosure itself had been an act of faith.

And I, fool of pattern, made a chapel of it.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 13 and 16, 2021. Returning to the therapy thread inside the parent strategy.

Lola: Do you think I should see a therapist?

Daniel: If you are at all worried about your mental health, you should.

Lola: I'm not worried about my mental health

Lola: I just don't know how to handle this situation

Daniel: But you are more or less the most switched on and responsible human I know.

Lola: When my parents found out when I was in Australia,

they made me go to a trauma therapist
Lola: My therapist was basically like It's ok to like older
guys,
it just depends on if they treat me well, etc.
and that It's ok to like/be interested in bdsm
Daniel: Ask the therapist how to help your parents
Lola: My family wouldn't listen to me
Lola: But they begrudgingly listened to my therapist
Lola: She was the only one who really heard me out and didn't
judge me
Daniel: Like when you tell them, they might be like,
you should see a therapist... and you can be like...
already done. Here's a note.
Lola: I'm scared to see a new therapist
Daniel: See the same one
Lola: I wouldn't know how to find her
Daniel: Maybe ask your parents.

[DANIEL]

This is one of the passages that refuses both my preferred innocence and my later condemnation. I did not tell her not to see a therapist. I told her to see one if she was worried. Then I also imagined the therapist as a credential, a note, a way to flip the family script. That is the mixture. Care and tactic. Protection and stagecraft. The same hand holding the blanket and the prop list.

She remembered someone who had heard her without judgment. I should have stopped there longer. I should have understood that the sentence contained the whole ethical problem: not how to persuade the parents, not how to make Daniel acceptable, not how to win New Year, but how to preserve the place where Lola could be heard without being converted into somebody's evidence.

Instead I saw a path through the family room.

[ANNOTATOR]

Therapy enters first as possible refuge, then as possible instrument. Daniel's authentic better act is visible inside the same exchange: he could have deferred to the hearing-place rather than recruiting it into the presentation strategy. Refuge is the form; instrumentalization is the consequence; the judgment is that even a good adult witness becomes unsafe if the lover imagines the witness primarily as a passport.

[FOOTNOTE 2]

This is one of the places where the selected page resists simple moral sorting. The same exchange contains courage, pressure, mutual fantasy, reasonable parental alarm, and Daniel's appetite for providential interpretation. Faith is the form; chapel is the consequence; the judgment is that a lover may turn another person's brave disclosure into an altar before noticing the sacrifice.

[DANIEL]

New Year, meanwhile, retreated. At first it had been Colorado, snow, my house, the collaring day I had imagined with an earnestness that embarrasses even the part of me still in love with the idea. Then it became negotiations, concerns, strategy, parental lunches, possible ultimatums. Then it became not New Year.

I say I expected this. That is not a lie. I had expected a wall because she had drawn one for me in advance: parents who watched closely, parents who had taken things away before, parents who did not like anybody she met, parents whose love moved through vigilance. I could be patient. I was patient. I was also theatrical about being patient, which is not quite the same virtue.

Late in that holiday drift, when travel talk and family weather and little cheerful photographs floated through the chat, we displaced the failed holiday into a future date.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 29, 2021. The date moves.

Daniel: I think June 5

Lola: June 5th for marriage?

Daniel: Yes.

Daniel: It is auspicious.

Lola: It is a most auspicious date

Daniel: To prepare you.

Lola: Prepare me? 😊

Daniel: Yes. And to ensure it is what your heart truly desires.

Lola: I only want to get married to one person in my entire life

Daniel: Hopefully you do not mind marrying him many times.

Lola: I think that that is a beautiful idea 🥰

[DANIEL]

An early-summer date acquired a little halo, chosen in that reckless almanac lovers keep under the tongue. We moved the impossible thing forward and called it auspicious. The deferred New Year became marriage; geography after geography auditioned for the privilege of absolving us.

Ladies and gentlemen, beware of lovers with calendars. They are more dangerous than lovers with knives. A knife has one future. A calendar has hundreds.

Still, there is tenderness in this page that I refuse to surrender. She wanted elegance. She wanted style. She wanted not a quickie but a life made deliberate. If I made too much of that, I made too much of something real.

[ANNOTATOR]

The word “marriage” is still private grammar here: calendar as charm, postponed New Year as wound, elegance as insistence that the lovers have not been reduced to appetite. The note should not let later categories

colonize this page too early. Daniel is already dangerous enough without borrowing danger from the future.

What matters is the displacement. A lost night becomes a chosen date; a missed ceremony becomes a better ceremony; absence is answered by design. Calendar is the form; deferral is the consequence; the judgment is that desire may call itself patience when it has found a future square to inhabit.

[DANIEL]

Then silence arrived, not all at once, but in drafts. The phone would show a deleted message. The little system notice, colder than any human sentence, would say she had been there and then withdrawn herself. A message deleted is more intimate than a message sent; it proves the hand approached the door.

I had promised, in one way or another, to honor her choices. I did honor them as best I could from inside the burning theater of myself. I wrote. I waited. I sent love into the blank. I was, I believed, non-obsessive. Even the felt-tip seems to pause over that adjective.

But here is the page as it stood:

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: December 31, 2021 through January 5, 2022. The waiting begins.

Daniel: I had very much hoped to begin this new year with you... in whatever capacity.

Daniel: Know that I will be thinking of you all day today and all day tomorrow and sending you whatever peace and happiness I can. 

Daniel: You are the woman I want to be with, and I will wait for you to become the woman who can be with me.

Daniel: There is a better universe where you began this new year

in my arms...

Daniel: If you are choosing to not communicate, I will trust that is for the best

Daniel: Good morning, my love. It has been a week since we've spoken. It seems an eternity ago. It seems like yesterday.

[DANIEL]

This is the slope on which I become dangerous to myself. I know it. I knew it less then, but not not at all. The waiting had two faces. One face was gentle: do what you must, preserve yourself, I will be here. The other face was a mirror in a locked room: every hour of silence returned my own love to me enlarged.

I made a theology of absence because absence was what I had. And then, as if a side door had opened in a museum after closing, there was Pinterest.

Not Pinterest as a lazy mind may imagine it: recipes, rooms, garments, sweetness flattened into little squares. Or yes, exactly that, but also the secret museum of the beloved's possible soul. She had once described it as barely social, a place of taste rather than performance. Barely social: an exquisite phrase, a fig leaf made of interface.

Pinterest was public enough to deny and private enough to worship. During that forbidden month I walked its corridors like a trespasser who had convinced himself he was an invited critic. Images of rooms, bodies, colors, jokes, sweets, captivity, love: each became, under the lunacy of separation, a dispatch.

Was she speaking to me? Was she speaking to herself?

Was I hearing language in wallpaper? One must not answer too quickly. To answer too quickly would be to acquit or convict the wrong person.

[RECONSTRUCTION]

I am not supposed to write to him, so I arrange little rooms no one can forbid. A room is not a message. A cake is not a message. A dress is only a dress unless someone has been taught to see the hem as yes and the ribbon as wait.

Today I pinned a kitchen because I wanted a kitchen. Also because he would see the light on the counter and think of morning. I do not know if I wanted that. I know I wanted to be seen without being caught being seen.

My parents think silence is clean. It is not. Silence makes fingerprints everywhere.

[ANNOTATOR]

The preceding leaf is an imagined pressure, not Lola's sworn interior. It is allowed to stand only because it bows before the threshold it cannot cross. Borrowed voice is the form; trespass is the consequence; the judgment is that sympathy must show its borrowed hands or become theft.

[DANIEL]

The actual channel was less pretty than my museum metaphor. It was not all cakes and rooms and dresses. It was also the blunt gray utility of a girl finding the one service no one had thought to confiscate.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Pinterest, January 5, 2022. The forbidden channel opens.

Lola: I'm so scared

Daniel: Why scared?

Lola: my family

Lola: i'm not supposed to be talking to you

Daniel: I figured

Lola: please don't let me go

Lola: I think they might pull me out of school...

Lola: I have no say or control

Lola: I have been crying for a week straight
Lola: I'm all alone
Lola: please wait for me
Daniel: I will post pins here for you to see... 🍷
Lola: I don't have access to electronics

[DANIEL]

There. That is the door. Not a secret rose pressed between pages. Not a scarf tied to a balcony. A young woman saying she was scared, that she had no access to electronics, that she had been crying, that she was not supposed to be speaking, and then speaking.

I did not invent the prohibition. She named it, or enough of it for memory to retain the shape: family, school, fear, electronics withheld, the loneliness of a house becoming a weather system.

But I did invent, or at least ratify, the romance of it. That is my portion. I did not merely say: this is a serious family crisis, let us slow down, let us find an adult, let us protect your school and your mind first. I said the things a lover says when the beloved appears at the prison window. I promised. I made destiny available. I made waiting beautiful.

And beauty is not harmless merely because it is beautiful.

[ANNOTATOR]

The prohibition is not inferred here; it speaks in the room. So does Lola's distress. Daniel answers with romantic continuity, which is not nothing, and not neutral care. Forbidden channel is the form; beautiful waiting is the consequence; the judgment is that rescue becomes claim the moment it loves the hidden road too much.

See also: *Diary of a Young Girl*, relation: Pinterest as forbidden diary-machine; *The Trial*, relation: electronics, family control, and accusation language reappear as legal facts with less mercy and more filing.

[DANIEL]

By the next turn in that hidden channel, the accusation language had acquired a terrible specificity. The adult words came into the channel like official men in bad shoes: trafficking, exploitation, safety, all the vocabulary by which terror tries to become competent.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Pinterest, January 7, 2022. Accusation enters the room.

Lola: I still love you now, but I cannot be open about it

Daniel: I know. Take your time.

Lola: They think you're a sex trafficker and that I don't know what I am doing

Lola: what is trafficking?

Lola: Also, I still don't have electronics

Lola: my parents were talking about him

Lola: pls dont talk about young girls being sexy

Lola: I have to go

[DANIEL]

One can hear, even through the flattened export, her recoil at the vocabulary the adults had placed around us. What is trafficking? Who is sexualized? Please do not talk about that. I wish I could say I handled those questions with the modesty they deserved. I explained. I contextualized. I intellectualized. I did that male thing, that father thing, that professor thing, that lover thing, where the frightened girl asks for less language and the man supplies more.

Not because I wanted to frighten her. I wanted to make the accusation legible and therefore less powerful. But legibility is not always mercy. Sometimes the kindest thing to do with a contaminated word is not to enlarge it on the page.

Still, there was another fact nested in the same ugly hour. She did not present herself as converted by the accusation. She presented herself as trapped by it.

This distinction became the foundation of my hidden-channel faith.

[RECONSTRUCTION]

They use words as if words are police. I ask what the word means and then wish I had not asked. If I do not know the word, I am naive. If I know the word, I am corrupted. There is no clean place to stand.

I still love him now. I wrote that because now is the only place they have not taken yet.

[ANNOTATOR]

The invented leaf does not own Lola's testimony. It only marks the pressure around the place where testimony has not been given. Reconstruction is the form; exposed absence is the consequence; the judgment is that an unwitnessed interior may be approached only as a locked door, never as a furnished room.

[DANIEL]

Then the domestic machinery of crisis began to show itself: school payments, therapist appointments, family therapy, background checks, the horrible little administrative verbs by which love becomes a file.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: Pinterest, January 10-11, 2022. School, therapist, and family leverage.

Lola: i found out that the first two weeks of school are virtual...

Lola: i hope my parents will still let me go back

Lola: i want my parents to meet you
Lola: I saw my mom was looking up stuff about teen dating violence
Lola: my dad said he research you for hours
Lola: I'll talk to my therapist tomorrow about a game plan/how to handle this with my parents
Lola: family therapy is friday
Lola: i think theyre going to threaten me
Lola: that if I talk wit u, they'll pull me out of school

[DANIEL]

This is the part anger would flatten, and therefore the part I must keep rough. Her parents were not merely screaming in the doorway. They were also paying for school, researching, consulting the vocabulary of safety, arranging therapy, trying, in their own terrified grammar, to prevent harm. They were wrong about me in ways that still make my hand dig into this page, but wrongness is not the same as emptiness.

The father did not become an antagonist because he lacked love for Lola. He became one because his love arrived as seizure. The mother did not become frightening because she had no tenderness. She became frightening because tenderness and surveillance are not opposites in a family house. They can share a coat.

And I, of course, was not outside this problem. I wanted to rescue her from control by becoming the meaning to which all escape pointed. I believed I was offering freedom. I can see, even now, how often freedom wore my face.

That is why Pinterest is the climax. It is January's most romantic chamber and its least innocent one.

It gave Lola a way to speak. It gave me a way to read.

Those are not the same gift.

[DANIEL]

There she is, and not there. That is the crisis. Not the bed, not the warrant, not the courtroom, not my birthday with its dead felt-tip pen. The crisis is this: a man in love with signs enters a gallery curated by a girl under watch, and every image becomes capable of saving or ruining him.

I believed I was reading her. I believed, more dangerously, that reading her was a form of care.

And perhaps sometimes it was. That is the little hook on which the whole dark fabric hangs. She was isolated. She was forbidden, or nearly forbidden, or forbidden enough. She had a language left to her made of fragments and plausible deniability. If I refused to read it, was I abandoning her? If I read too much, was I stealing her?

No court form has a checkbox for this.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: The winter waiting, with the larger Pinterest weather held outside this page.

Daniel: We will have to make our opera extra interesting to make up for this intolerable intermission...

Daniel: Given the excitement and romance thusfar, I think the audience will be patient...

Daniel: I have today been away from you for three weeks.

Daniel: Maddening that I cannot.

Daniel: That you have messaged me a couple of times on messenger and deleted them adds a bit of mystery.

Daniel: Ultimately, I have faith in you to make good choices for yourself. And I will honor those choices, whatever they are.

[DANIEL]

"The audience will be patient." I wrote that. I blush to see it and love it still. Even deprived of audience, I invented one; even deprived of stage, I

invented opera. I was still making art of endurance, which is noble until it is not.

This was not a new conceit. Isibella and I had lived, for a time, under the sign of the same invisible house lights: the belief that we were inside a story, and that our choices ought to be beautiful, yes, but also believable to the audience watching from the dark. Not moral. Not prudent. Believable. There is a difference, and I had mistaken the difference for sophistication.

So when I wrote of patience, I was not inventing a jury. Not yet. I was invoking the older theatre where love became truer by imagining itself observed. The audience had followed me from one romance into another like a debt with better seats.

I did not understand that some audiences do not applaud or condemn. Some simply remember the bargain. They sit behind the velvet dark with no program in their hands, waiting to see whether the lovers know what they have promised and what price a promise requires.

The forbidden-month pages belong to Lola more than to me, and therefore belong to fiction more than demonstration. They stand beside these pages, not beneath them, a small lit window across the alley. I can imagine her there; I cannot own the imagining. Some colder reader may underline that sentence twice, no doubt, and spill tea on it for emphasis.

After the hidden channel, the ordinary channels reopened enough for the next entrance to arrive in ordinary clothes. No thunder. No black envelope. The font returned to normal; the little typing dots resumed their vulgar pulse.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: January 22, 2022. Valentine's becomes a parent gate.

Lola: My parents want to meet you before we can see each other again

Lola: I was kinda hoping I could see you for Valentine's Day

Daniel: We'll figure it out. Are they down to meet in NY?

Lola: So no Valentine's Day?

Lola: I was kinda thinking that you could collar me on Valentine's Day

Lola: You'll have to meet my parents before seeing me

Lola: It's their rule

Daniel: Sure.

Daniel: We'll plan something

Daniel: I am very parent friendly.

Lola: My parents are scared of you

Daniel: I will put them at ease.

Daniel: I am excited to meet your parents!

[DANIEL]

There is the hinge in its least ornamental form: see each other again, Valentine's Day, collar, parents, rule. The pages will move toward travel soon enough, but not yet. What matters here is not yet the restaurant, not yet the table, not yet whether a father extended a hand at the right temperature.

What matters is the expectation. The forbidden month had made us clandestine. The next threshold promised to make us visible. I mistook the second condition for the healing of the first. Surely if one survives concealment and then appears before parents, the narrative is advancing toward legitimacy. Surely a hidden channel, once no longer needed, becomes merely a quaint emergency passage in the architecture of love.

Surely is the word by which fools enter rooms. What matters here is that by the time Valentine's appeared, the romance had survived by changing state. It had passed from voice to silence, from silence to image, from image to interpretation. I did not know, not really, what had been preserved in that passage.

I only knew that I loved her. Worse: I loved the passage too.

Act III Endnotes

[III.1] The selected sequence follows pressure rather than completeness: discovery, mother, father, New Year, waiting, the forbidden channel, accusation, Valentine's gate. Selection is the form; pressure is the consequence; the judgment is that the gaps are part of the room and must not be plastered over by beauty.

[III.2] The mother enters first as reader, not monster. She guesses. Guessing is the form; household reading is the consequence; the judgment is that Daniel admires the intelligence of that guess because he can still imagine parental love as rival authorship rather than force.

[III.3] The New Year invitation is built from permission language: ask your mother, tell your father, meet the parents, make the private thing presentable. Asking is the form; ritualized consent is the consequence; the judgment is that refusal can begin to look, to him, like a failed ceremony rather than an answer.

[III.4] June 5 is not a stable plan so much as a displacement device. New Year fails; the lovers move the charge forward and call the new date auspicious. Calendar is the form; postponed ceremony is the consequence; the judgment is that desire may borrow patience's coat and walk out wearing it.

[III.5] Pinterest is not a complete archive here; it is a chamber of selected pressure. Forbidden channel is the form; interpretive hunger is the consequence; the judgment is that its oddities should not be smoothed into chronology, because some lines survive in an order stranger than memory would choose.

[III.6] Any Lola-perspective diary leaves inside this book are threshold objects, not testimony. Borrowed voice is the form; possible theft is the consequence; the judgment is that sympathy is dangerous unless the note keeps showing its borrowed hands.

[III.7] The accusation vocabulary enters early. Naming is the form; contamination is the consequence; the judgment is that Daniel cannot pretend those words were invisible, and Lola's recoil is one of the places where the page should lower its voice.

[III.8] The next threshold is Valentine's Day: the trip, the parent meeting, the collaring, and the cancellation weather around the public festival that does not happen. Gate is the form; public visibility is the promised consequence; the judgment is that a hidden road does not become harmless because it reaches a lit doorway.

Act IV

[ANNOTATOR]

This Act begins after the most beautiful token Daniel can still name without touching it: the Valentine's collar, rose gold, circular, grammatical in the way a ring is grammatical. It made a sentence around Lola's throat and persuaded him that the sentence had been mutually authored. Token is the form; mutual authorship is the temptation; the judgment is that a charged thing may keep acting after the hands disagree about its office.

What follows is the danger of that persuasion. Spring Break is not yet event; it is still design, itinerary, threat, ceremony, hunger, token. Daniel will remember the beauty first because beauty is how he organized trespass before consequence found its mortal name. Design is the form; future room

is the consequence; the judgment is that a ceremony can begin to bind before it happens.

This is where Lola's counter-voice matters most. The messages must not be treated as decoration around Daniel's jealousy. They are the floor under it. She names wanting, friendship, devotion, fear, health, and limits, sometimes in the same breath. Daniel hears an oath fraying. The note hears the page becoming less obedient to romance. Counter-voice is the form; disobedient evidence is the consequence; the judgment is that a beloved who contradicts the pattern has not thereby ceased to speak.

[YELLOW PAD]

I still prefer my paper, because form is a treacherous little god, and because another door was already waiting with its teeth in the wood. After Valentine's Day, Spring Break was still there, waiting for us.

It had become a place we could almost touch. Not a plan, exactly. Plans require adults, money, permission, weather, lies that hold. This was more fragile and more potent: a room imagined before it existed, a city reduced to food and a bed, both of us pretending not to know which noun had begun to glow.

That was how close it still felt: close enough for the future to fog the glass.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: February 24, 2022. Spring Break still appears possible.

Daniel: What are your thoughts about Spring Break?

Lola: I want to be with you

Daniel: That is really all that I want.

Daniel: So... maybe you will just fly here and we can pop out to Vegas for a couple nights. ;)

Lola: What's there to do in Vegas besides clubbing or gambling?

Daniel: I don't club or gamble

Lola: I don't either 😊

Daniel: I do eat.

Lola: Mmm food

Daniel: And I do fuck slavegirls.

Lola: Are you saying that we will have sex in Vegas?

Daniel: We might...

Daniel: If you beg.

Daniel: But we will probably have sex here first.

Lola: Hehe

Lola: Sec 😊

Lola: Sex

Alex arrived by accident.

Not dramatically. Not as a confession. A name appeared, then corrected itself, and suddenly there was another person beside her in the life I could not enter.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: February 26, 2022. Photos, Pippin, Alex.

Lola: I watched Pippin with Alec

Lola: *Alex

Lola: [PHOTO]

Lola: 😊

Daniel: Cool.

She had watched something with Alex while I was elsewhere under grander lights. Not in a theatre, I think. A laptop, which is worse in its own small way: not public darkness but shared little light, two faces close enough to be lit by the same screen. That detail may be memory or invention's little repair; either way, it stayed because it knew how to hurt me.

I did not need a revelation. Alex was they in the world, but jealousy is a poor grammarian. In my head they became he: easier to fight, easier to accuse, easier to imagine beside the girl I had already made my fiancée, both of them lit by that small blue theatre where I had not been invited.

Lola had a way of turning attention into climate. The question was never whether someone would want her. The question was whether she would tell the truth about being wanted.

My mind wanted a role for Alex before the facts had earned one: rival, page, imp, helpful boy with quick hands at the edge of the scene. That was unfair to them and faithful to my fear. Mischief does not need guilt to change the blocking.

She made them harmless in the telling. Friend. Nothing. Nobody standing between us.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: February 26, 2022. The law is written.

Lola: She's a bad human for even cheating on you

Lola: Have higher standards 😊

Daniel: Is why I have you.

Lola: And even though I only like Alex as a friend,
I made it clear to them that I am very devoted to you
(emotionally and physically).

Lola: So I'm just saying that I lay out the law with people

Lola: Because I know you deserve more

Lola: And I would never cheat on you

Daniel: I am entirely devoted to you.

Lola: That's such a low move and I am still surprised that Isi
is such a stupid fucking cunt to treat you like shit
and disregard you for a new dick

Daniel: And I will never cheat on you.

Daniel: It's not in my nature.

Lola: And I classify cheating as being physically intimate
with another person (like touching their breast/private
areas,

having oral or penetrative sex)

Lola: Stuff like that

Daniel: I take magick very seriously.

Lola: Me too, Master ❤️

Daniel: I think cheating is actually far more than just being

physically intimate.

Lola: What we have is much more than Master and slavegirl or anything physically

Lola: I was going to say

Lola: Physically cheating is that to me

Daniel: You have my heart.

Lola: But there can also be emotional

Lola: You have my heart, Master ❤️

Daniel: I could not and would not share it with anyone else.

Daniel: I am very protective of it.

Lola: I could not and will not share my heart with anyone else

❤️

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: February 27, 2022. The favorite question returns.

Daniel: I will keep you.

Daniel: For ever.

Daniel: For all ways.

Lola: Keep me forever, Master

Daniel: I want you in ways that are probably unhealthy,,,

Daniel: I want you completely

Lola: How so, Master?

Daniel: Like I really like being obsessed with you

Daniel: It's really quite comfortable

Lola: I love you being obsessed with me, Master

Lola: It is 😊

Lola: May I ask a question, Master

Daniel: Like what I am meant to do

Lola: 😊

Daniel: You may ask a question

Daniel: It's my favorite thing, you know...

Lola: That's why I ask 😊

Lola: So I am very little... I just identify with being a little

Lola: It's part of who I am

Lola: I feel that I have a hard time balancing being a slave and a little

Daniel: How so?

Lola: Like sometimes I act more childish and little/bratty when you just want me to follow orders

Then she talked about Isi.

She did not call cheating sad, or confusing, or human. She made it vile. She made it stupid. She made it the kind of thing a person did only when she had decided another person's heart no longer counted.

Then she went further. Isi became, in Lola's mouth, the example of betrayal made obscene. I remember the ugliness of the phrase more than I trust the stenographer in my head.

She said she would not cheat, or said enough that I heard a vow.

She drew the line herself. Physical, emotional, the whole country of betrayal mapped and named. Then she gave me the sentence I wanted most.

You have my heart.

I could not and will not share my heart with anyone else.

Then, almost without changing temperature, she asked permission to ask again. That was one of her arts. She could make the door smaller and more irresistible at the same time: Can I ask a question, Master. As if curiosity had curtsied before entering. As if the question were not already inside the room, touching everything.

What she asked was not a seduction only. It was a problem of form. How to be little and slave, childish and obedient, adored and ordered, free enough to ask and owned enough to need permission. She was not a canvas lying still under my hand. She was already arguing with the picture.

Then she did it.

Within the week.

I have misread many things. I have embroidered and excused and arranged coincidences into patterns because I could not bear the plainness of pain. But this was plain enough for jail memory. Lola met Alex. I felt the danger. She denied it. She condemned betrayal, then crossed the line I believed she had just drawn.

I did not need to invent that.

[PORTFOLIO PAGE]

Caption: February 28, 2022. A link, a project, unfinished photographs.

Lola: <https>

Lola: I haven't added all of the final photos yet

Lola: I just want chu to look over the writing bit

After that, the next thing I remember is the title.

deconstruct-reconstruct

It was a Parsons assignment. A title attached to writing and photographs and some half-finished page she wanted me to look over.

But titles have relatives. Near it in memory was the earlier Mind and Body work: a map of pressure, a canvas, body and time and fear made half-legible by arrows. Parents. Control. Connection. A line about wanting to be her own person; another about the guide or partner in her life. There were contour lines like weather systems or fingerprints, plans for heat, hidden light, the body itself used as a tool, a stamp, a method for leaving contact behind.

I know. It was coursework. A girl trying to finish a project.

But the work had another light. Under ordinary light the canvas was black and white, body against darkness, contact reduced to pale residue. Under the hidden light, sentences surfaced like contraband thought: impressions,

time, what contact leaves on the body. And, if memory has not embroidered the corner beyond recognition, the little married name hiding where ordinary looking would not find it: Mrs. Lola McShan.

The hidden layer did not contradict the visible one. It accused it of being incomplete.

She had made a map of influence and called it a body. Or I called it that for her, which is already the danger. She had made touch visible, then made visibility conditional. She had written fear and parents and control into the same field as partner and connection. She had made, without meaning to make it for me, the object I was most fatally prepared to worship, and the object did what true objects do: it kept some of itself cold under my hand.

Still, the title remained.

The promise came apart. The law came apart. The girl who had told me never and heart and mine was suddenly somewhere else, making room for friends, fear, pressure, balance, Alex.

Then the word friends changed temperature.

Alex was no longer a correction. They were part of the weather. Or he was, once jealousy had finished dressing them for the part.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: March 4, 2022. Friends.

Lola: I think that it's healthy for me to have friends

Lola: Im sorry if I haven't communicated clearly,
but it really feels like it's all or nothing

Lola: Like I can either be with you OR have friends,
but that I can't have both

Lola: I don't know what to do or how to handle this

Lola: I'm also friends with simhita and yilin and Hanna and Ria

and Tyler

and Jaiden and Ryan and Mia and Lyndsey and others

Lola: I hang out with them and call them and talk to them

Daniel: You can and should have friends and still communicate with me.

Daniel: But I don't think that is the issue.

Lola: What is the issue?

Daniel: I wouldn't know

Daniel: As I've not talked to you all week.

Daniel: But I would assume that you've had friends the past five months.

Daniel: So something is different.

Lola: Well I just made friends with Yilin, Alex, and Samhita

Daniel: I think it is that subconsciously you have decided that it's easier to drift apart as you are not coming for spring break.

Lola: No

Lola: I don't want to drift apart

Daniel: Then don't.

Lola: I won't

Daniel: Okay

Lola: Oki

I was too much. Love, in me, did not know how to stay small. I heard friends and heard distance. I heard Alex and heard the thing she had promised would not happen.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: March 5, 2022. Fragile state, sleep, and refusal.

Lola: I feel so fragile right now

Lola: and I feel like I need to process what I'm feeling

Daniel: Just get some sleep.

Lola: okay ;-;

Daniel: I'm sorry I can't be there for you.

Lola: it is hard ;-;

Daniel: Or here for you.

Daniel: Or wherever I should be

Daniel: I don't think I'm doing a very good job

Lola: I am falling asleep

Daniel: Sweet dreams.
Lola: sweet dreams!
Daniel: Anyways, I am sad.
Lola: I am sorry
Daniel: It's not your fault.
Daniel: You are doing the best you can.
Daniel: I just need... not this.
Lola: I am in a very fragile state
Lola: I cannot communicate well right now
Daniel: I wish I could know why.
Lola: I don't know
Lola: I am feeling a million things
Daniel: And it makes it very obvious that you are no longer in love with me.
Lola: I am sorry but I really need to get some sleep...
Can we please continue this conversation tomorrow?
Daniel: No.
Daniel: I'm really not interested.
Lola: so then should we break up?
Daniel: And you have given me no reason to be interested.
Daniel: What's to break up?
Daniel: You are already decided.
Daniel: I'm unimpressed.
Daniel: You can't even break up with me.
Daniel: Fine.
Daniel: You are released.
Daniel: Take off your collar.
Lola: Because I am trying to work through my emotions
and understand how I am feeling before I do anything rash
Daniel: Your are a fool.
Daniel: Choices have consequences.
Daniel: You chose.
Daniel: I did warn you.
Daniel: Good bye.
Lola: good bye
Daniel: Live well, my love.
Daniel: I will continue to live in your dream for you.
Daniel: Do not speak to me again.

[DANIEL]

There is no need to improve this page. Improvement would be an obscenity. She asks for sleep. She asks to continue tomorrow. She says she is fragile, that she cannot communicate well, that she is trying to understand before doing anything rash. I answer with drama sharp enough to mistake itself for honesty.

Here, at last, quotation does what confession cannot. It shows the hinge cutting. I can say I was hurt; the page shows where hurt became refusal. I can say I wanted communication; the page shows where I denied the request to continue communicating later. I can say the collar was removable; the page shows me ordering removal as punishment and exit at once.

“You are released” may be the ugliest mercy in the book. It offers the door by striking the threshold.

[ANNOTATOR]

This is the necessary expansion because it prevents Daniel’s later account from summarizing the rupture as betrayal alone. Lola names incapacity and asks for time. Daniel hears abandonment and performs finality. Request for delay is the form; refused tomorrow is the consequence; the judgment is that a Stalker who cannot allow sleep has lost the office before the court names anything.

We still said marriage. Even then, with Spring Break already loosening under us, we still said it.

But being too much did not make the other fact disappear.

She had made a law and broken it.

Or that was the sentence I could bear. Law, broken: a little kingdom I could carry in my pocket. It made her legible again, briefly. It gave the beautiful creature a fence, a transgression, a shape.

Then she moved in the shape, and the shape failed. That was the unbearable part. Betrayal still kept her inside my grammar. Fear did too. Even rebellion did. But Lola was not only betraying, fearing, rebelling, promising, or failing. She was changing relation to the page itself, becoming less a figure in my romance than a living pressure against its margins.

The rules I trusted were modern ones because modern rules can be typed, signed, revised, attached. Consent. Contract. Collar. Itinerary. I believed a door became ethical when both people admired the hinge and signed their admiration.

But some older grammar kept shining underneath, not as doctrine, not as superstition, only as the pressure certain words acquired when Lola used them. Permission before desire. A name offered and withheld. A threshold made thrilling by refusal. A gift that might be a bond. A question that asked leave after it had already altered the room. Even silence, with her, had entrances.

Lola knew how to ask before asking. That was part of the enchantment and part of the danger. The courtesy bowed; then the question entered; then the room was not quite the room it had been.

There are stories in which a person is undone because he cannot tell whether he has been invited, chosen, mocked, tested, crowned, or merely overheard. I did not think I was living inside one. I thought I was a modern man with documents. Yet the old motions were everywhere: politeness at the threshold, the dangerous gift, the name that changed shape when spoken by jealousy, the beloved who could be addressed and still not be summoned, the promise that sounded like freedom until one heard the bargain breathing inside it.

I could accuse her more easily than I could see her. Accusation kept her where motive has furniture and betrayal can be made to sit in a chair. But Lola kept slipping toward the edge of the scene: not innocent, not guilty in

any size I could hold, asking first and entering anyway, leaving behind the shimmer of an agreement I could feel more clearly than I could repeat.

I had wanted a contract. I had wanted a door. I had wanted a beloved who would enter it freely and remain legible once inside. Instead the door opened onto weather, and the weather had her manners.

Sometimes, when the tier goes quiet enough for the lights to hum, I think I hear a room tuning itself without us. Not music. Not judgment. Only the little preliminary cruelty of instruments finding pitch while the actors still believe the door is only a door.

Spring Break waited, already impossible.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: March 12-13, 2022. One-sided after-weather.

Daniel: Now, let me teach you how to break up with someone you love...

Daniel: Miss Lola, I do not need to tell you that I love you.

It is obvious in my every word and every deed.

Daniel: However, this lack of communication the past week is intolerable

and not conducive to a healthy relationship.

Daniel: I have done my very best to give you an opportunity to avoid the future you have chosen

Daniel: But you always had a choice.

Daniel: So, be brave, my love.

Daniel: The future is going to get pretty awful sometimes.

Daniel: I am sorry you lacked the courage to join me.

Daniel: I love you.

Daniel: There is nothing that I wouldn't do.

[CONTACT NOTICE]: You blocked this contact

[CONTACT NOTICE]: You unblocked this contact

Daniel: ...and so things end as they began.

Daniel: I know that it is over and that you had to return to your reality.

Daniel: I was but a dream...

Daniel: I hope it served its purpose for you
 and that you awake ready to face the real world.

Daniel: It has been about a week since you took that NyQuil...

Daniel: ...rather than talk to me

Daniel: You have forgotten childhood wonder...

Daniel: This was to awaken it in you.

Daniel: I brought out the best in you.

Daniel: I accept that there is something vital I need to know

Daniel: And I accept that I will never know it

Daniel: Still, weird you are not mine.

Daniel: I know you haven't made your mind up yet...

Daniel: We don't have to communicate.

Daniel: I could just read you the story.

Daniel: I think your parents freaked out about Spring Break
 and forced you with some sort of ultimatum
 saying you could not speak to me again.

Daniel: That is what I think happened.

Daniel: It's more poetic.

Daniel: Forbidden road-trips and over-protective mothers.

Daniel: If our love is not true, it will wither and die.

Daniel: But if, as I surmise, it is True,
 it will grow until it overcomes even your love for your
 family.

Daniel: Stay true. Wear your collar. Be a good girl.
 I will wait for you.

Daniel: I want to develop classes and technologies
 that can assist communities in dealing with these complex,
 "bleeding edge" human relationships

Daniel: I want to encourage and emphasize Radical Communication.

Daniel: I need you for inspiration.

Daniel: I need our relationship as a shining example of how to
 do it right.

Daniel: I need your voice.

Daniel: The Universe needs your voice.

Daniel: You don't have to, of course. There are other Voices.
 I just fancy yours.

[DANIEL]

The after-weather is embarrassing because it keeps changing costumes.
 Farewell, blessing, accusation, pedagogy, fairy tale, research proposal,

consent manifesto, invitation, command. I blocked and unblocked, which is to say I made a door into an instrument and then pretended the instrument was a door. The page records the toggle with a cruelty no metaphor can improve.

It is also here that my future defense first starts dressing itself. Radical Communication. Consent culture. Classes and technologies. I needed her voice, I said, and that was true enough to be dangerous. I needed her voice not only because she was a person I loved, but because her voice would keep my beautiful theory from looking like a theory built over her silence.

This is why the later dissertation cannot merely collect commandments. The commandments were already trying to be born here, in the wrong order, before apology, before consequence, before I had accepted that a beloved's silence might be an answer I was not authorized to translate.

[ANNOTATOR]

The one-sided March after-weather is the bridge into The Trial because it shows the self-exonerating apparatus before legal counsel, before verdict, before the mature Stalker doctrine. Daniel does not simply pursue Lola; he begins converting the failed relationship into a public theory that requires her voice. Theory is the form; appropriation risk is the consequence; the judgment is that consent language can become coercive when it needs the injured party to complete its proof.

[PHONE PAGE]

Caption: March 6-14, 2022. Communication is not constructive, and the barred road.

Lola: Daniel, I appreciate that we've spent time together,
but we've reached a point in our relationship where
communication is not constructive.

Lola: You had asked me not to contact you anymore,
however, you have then reached out to me several times.

Lola: I'm recognizing that what's best for each of us is to not communicate with each other anymore.

Lola: I will not contact you and I ask that you not contact me in any form and I wish you all the best.

Daniel: How does one reach a point in a relationship where communication is not constructive?

Daniel: What does that even mean?

Daniel: "We've reached a point in our relationship where communication is not constructive"

Daniel: ...was not your safeword.

Daniel: But it will make for interesting art.

Daniel: Is there any way we can just talk?

Daniel: Just say goodbye if that's what it is

Daniel: If that's what you really want, you don't have to explain

Daniel: But you should tell me what you want.

Daniel: Call me.

Daniel: Even if it is to say goodbye

Daniel: Maybe I should message your parents...

Daniel: Are you still wearing your collar?

Daniel: Say oui.

Daniel: We – literally you and I – need to change the world.

Daniel: Our Art is Our Life

Daniel: That collar defines you.

Daniel: You are mine.

Daniel: It is not so much a possession thing like ownership...

Daniel: It's more a possession thing like the supernatural.
My existence permeates you...

[DANIEL]

This is the page I would least like to exhibit and most need to keep. Lola's sentence was not ornate. That was part of my objection to it. It sounded administrative, adult, borrowed from some office of self-protection that I did not recognize as the beloved's true voice. I mistook dryness for falseness. I treated the lack of poetry as evidence that the road was still open.

The error is exact. She said communication was no longer constructive. I asked what that meant, as if etymology were an appeal. Then I kept building. I built art over the refusal, doctrine over the refusal, a theory of possession over the refusal, and finally a future in which her saying no could be recast as the dramatic obstacle a truer yes would overcome.

The later court will call this contact. The Fae court will call it bad guidance. The human record is simpler: she asked for no contact in any form. I answered by translating form into symbol.

[ANNOTATOR]

Communication means the thing made common. Constructive means building. Once Lola says the common house is no longer being built, Daniel's next words do not arrive neutrally. They carry stones for a wall. This is the bridge from romance into evidence: not because feeling ended, but because feeling continued to claim architectural rights after the door had been barred.

Act IV Endnotes

1. The messages preserve Daniel's strange erotic grammar: sex deferred behind token, contract, marriage, and ceremonials of respect. Paper and threshold are not decorative; they are how he teaches himself to believe danger has become ethical. Deferral is the form; ethical glamour is the consequence; the judgment is that danger does not become clean because it waits behind paperwork.
2. Spring Break cuts against Daniel's sex-negative self-description. He says "We might..." when Lola asks whether he means sex in Vegas. Contradiction is the form; ritual pressure is the consequence; the judgment is that desire hidden behind ceremony still arrives with a body.

3. Alex enters as an ordinary social fact, not as verdict. Correction is the form; splinter is the consequence; the judgment is that the small change from Alec to Alex becomes large because Daniel preserves it where jealousy can keep touching it.
4. Lola states devotion, defines physical and emotional cheating, condemns Isi, and promises not to cheat. Daniel also promises: “I will never cheat on you.” Vow is the form; reciprocal blade is the consequence; the judgment is that her law receives its full weight when his matching instrument remains beside it.
5. “May I ask a question, Master” returns inside a negotiated identity problem: little, slave, obedience, childishness, permission, and desire. Role is the form; contest inside obedience is the consequence; the judgment is that Lola is neither inert victim nor stable co-author, but the one who contests the role while using its language.
6. The collar messages refuse a single clean temperature. Lola calls the collar beautiful and a symbol of mutual devotion. Token is the form; unstable office is the consequence; the judgment is that here the collar remains devotion, possession, costume, proof, and contested sign without changing shape.
7. Alex becomes theatrical only later. Here the thing is smaller and worse: an ordinary friend enters through art-school life, and Daniel’s romance discovers how quickly theatre can convert a person into a role. Role is the form; miscasting is the consequence; the judgment is that the older machinery is already present as pressure, not explanation: names, bargains, thresholds, permissions, disguises, and the courtly terror of a question asked too politely.
8. The portfolio trace survives unevenly: fragment, address, vanished page. Title is the form; self-reading is the consequence; the judgment is that deconstruct, reconstruct is enough to begin doing literary work

because the romance is already trying to pass through its own machinery.

9. The Parsons materials complicate the narrator's treatment of Deconstruct/Reconstruct as mere title. Mind and Body is distinct, but adjacent in pressure: map, parents, fear, control, connection, partner, body, hidden light, the body as tool and stamp. Hidden layer is the form; conditional visibility is the consequence; the judgment is that Daniel's remembered invisible-ink married name may pressure the prose, but the current images do not plainly swear for it. These are not illustrations; they are pressure on the prose.
10. The March 4 messages complicate Daniel's memory of friends as threat. Friend is the form; all-or-nothing pressure is the consequence; the judgment is that Daniel says the generous thing and then cannot inhabit it. Lola says the relationship feels all or nothing; Daniel answers that she can and should have friends while still communicating with him.
11. The token exchange is where Daniel's consent-art begins to show its teeth. He frames the collar as chosen symbol and removable sign, but the language narrows around possession, authenticity, training, and whether Lola can remain little without remaining his slave. Removability is the form; narrowing claim is the consequence; the judgment is that a token may be removable and still bite.
12. The ceremony waits and already fails: the room has been imagined, the law has been written, the token has been loved, and the word friends has changed temperature. Waiting ceremony is the form; prior failure is the consequence; the judgment is that a room imagined too early may begin failing before anyone enters it.
13. The note does not win by explaining Lola. Daniel's romance is one form of enclosure; annotation can become another. Refusal of

possession is the form; Lola's excess is the consequence; the judgment is that she evades both. Not mist, not innocence, not a solved victim, but a beautiful, dangerous, living creature whose traces exceed the uses made of them. The later pattern is present only as pressure: rooms, permissions, names, bargains, weighed paper, reweighed paper, and a music not yet heard. Here the door should be felt, not labeled; even the note should hesitate before mistaking a keyhole for a key.

Epilogue

[ANNOTATOR]

At the end, Daniel is allowed the last continuous voice and denied the last possession. No message arrives to correct him. No outside file opens like a rescue door. The page becomes witness and refusal at once: Daniel speaks; the note listens; Lola remains partly outside both operations.

[YELLOW PAD]

There is a point at which a story stops being private even if no one has finished telling it.

I do not know, writing this, what name they will give me. I do not know what Lola has said, or not said, or been asked to remember under lights I cannot see. I know only the miserable comedy of paper: the same messages that once made a room for us can now be laid flat on a table and taught to point.

That is the danger of building a love story out of tokens. Tokens do not stay grateful.

I would like to end beautifully. Of course I would. I would like to give you one last token of light, one last sentence with its throat tilted back, one last gleaming proof that the whole thing was stranger and finer than the category waiting for it outside this cell.

But the pen is failing.

The felt tip has gone soft from pressure. It drags now, leaving small dry gaps in the letters, so even my handwriting has begun to plead and stutter. Somewhere down the row a man is laughing at something I cannot hear. The lights remain lights. The bunk remains a bunk. My birthday has almost finished being useful.

Lola does not arrive.

The page does.

[ANNOTATOR]

The manuscript ends before the house is opened by other hands, before the private pages learn colder manners, before anyone has been paid to decide what these pages mean. Another chamber begins when love is no longer the only reader. Even that chamber will have to learn that it has arrived too late to own what happened here.

Other chambers will try their manners on the story: one where paper is held up to light, another where the same paper is lifted by a colder hand, another where music makes mischief and ravishment audible only after paper has done its damage. They wait outside this book. They must not be pressed backward into it as keys. Still, the locks have begun to dream, and the hinges remember more than either speaker intends.

The shelf names are not secret to the note: *The Trial*, *The Sentence*, *The Appeal*, *The Opera*, *Diary of a Young Girl*, *Diary of a Stalker*, *Twenty Dollar Words*. Their order is not innocence. Each will try a

different instrument on the same body of evidence: warrant, penalty, argument, score, restricted diary, obsessive address, unlovely lexicon. The Annotator may point. The pointing hand is not clean: selection is authorship, authorship is custody, and custody is liability.

Here the pressure is only a draft under the door: tokens, bargains, names, thresholds, permission asked before desire speaks, and Lola's most disarming courtesy, "Can I ask a question?" The yellow page has no doctrine for it. It has a beloved who will not arrive, and the remembered sensation that some questions opened rooms before either lover knew what law governed the room. The later pattern should be felt first as etiquette becoming peril.

The old story-pattern is visible only in negative: a name that is not safely a name, a bargain disguised as consent, an invitation that may also be a trap, a warning admired for its calligraphy, a masked beloved who is most herself when she cannot be finally identified. If later rooms hear that pressure more plainly, this book should hear it first as weather: a rustle at the threshold, a courtesy too bright to trust, a tune remembered before anyone admits there was music.

The sequence matters. First the private room mistakes consent for a perfect spell. Then a colder room mistakes pages for a perfect net. Then the paper is lifted again, as if a different hand might make the light more honest. Then music discovers what neither paper nor punishment could hold: that a question can be invitation, accusation, courtesy, curse, and art at once. None of this absolves Daniel. It only makes his preferred absolutions too small, and his preferred categories too coarse for the creature he keeps trying to name. The note must make the same confession about itself.

Form: tokened romance. Consequence: the private room becomes portable evidence. Judgment: every beautiful object kept past its office begins looking for a court.

Cross-reference: *The Trial* begins with the warrant and learns how messages become instruments; *The Sentence* measures the body after the verdict; *The Appeal* argues over the record's meanings; *The Opera* refuses prose by making the machinery sing. These are not sequels as escape routes. They are rooms in which this book's unresolved ethics continue to misbehave.

[ANNOTATOR]

This ending is not an acquittal by memory and not a conviction by the note. It is the point at which Lola's surviving fragments refuse both operations. She is not only the beloved. She is not only the accusing figure colder rooms will require. She is not only the girl in danger, the artist among pages, the fiancée marked by a token, the student with parents, the witness some later room will ask to remember.

She is the voice asking whether a question may be asked, and then asking it anyway. Any later theory, any later music must begin by admitting this: the question was hers before it became anyone's symbol. Courtesy is not innocence. Enchantment is not exoneration. A threshold can be real even when both people call it a game.

The note would like to pretend this is wisdom. It is not. It is only a second fascination with better stationery. A footnote can become a little cage; so can sympathy, so can sequence, so can the elegant refusal to judge. The book leaves Lola escaping not only Daniel's romance, but Daniel's explanation of the romance, and then the explanation of the explanation: the creature still beautiful, still dangerous, still partly untranslatable after every exhibit has been numbered, still not safely inside any human sentence about her.

Afterword

L'affaire Lolita

After doing my impersonation of suave John Ray, the character in *Lolita* who pens the Foreword, any comments coming straight from me may strike one—may strike me, in fact—as an impersonation of Vladimir Nabokov talking about his own book.¹ To perhaps help contextualize this particular enchantment, it is worthwhile to tell you about my background and how it is that I have come to live a fiction of Nabokov.

My mother was an English major, to which I credit my life long love of literature. My home was filled with books from her studies and the science fiction my father read. The first novel I fell in love with was Andre Gide's *Strait is the Gate*, a largely epistolary novel exploring the themes of impossible love. I still have a fetish for impossible love. I also enjoy epistles.

My father is also a gentle, easy-going person. He had earned a Ph.D. in low energy nuclear physics a year before I was born. His dissertation was entitled, "A Study of Erbium-168 By Isobaric Analog Resonance Technique".

Apparently a puzzle of the late sixties.

WITHIN THE LAST FIVE YEARS, exploitation of isobaric analog resonances to obtain detailed information concerning the structure of atomic nuclei has become a standard, if somewhat mysterious, technique in the repertoire of experimental nuclear physicists. The precise nature and structure of isobaric analog resonances in nuclei are apparently not well understood by anyone at the present time, because the nuclear configurations involved are exceedingly complicated[1]

From him perhaps I have learned that if you are going to invest energy into something, it might as well be something mysterious that is not well

understood. Analog Resonance Technique. At certain energies, Erbium-168 (68 protons, 100 neutrons) can become Thulium-168 (69 protons, 99 neutrons). You see, protons and neutrons are, in fact, the same particle (a nucleon) differing only in the (relatively weak) electromagnetic charge. So close, it seems, that they can resonate between each other at certain energies.

He is a professor emeritus medical physicist working in the field of Radiation Oncology, developing three dimensional treatment planning systems for cancer at the University Hospital. He is an excellent father, husband and academic. More or less everything I am not.

I first encountered that famous book by Nabokov when I was 18 years old, volunteering in the University Hospital where he worked. I picked up some volunteer shifts in the library. I'd wanted to volunteer with dementia patients, but the shifts weren't available. I went to the chaplain to volunteer, but they also didn't have anything for me. So I ended up in the patient's library. Looking on the shelves of the small library, I found the paperback of *Lolita* in the fiction section. I am quite confident that nobody I knew at that time had read it, or recommended it. To be perfectly fair, that is probably still the case. So I picked it up, read it, loved it... and stole it. In fairness, at the time, I was using the library as intended.

Stamped inside the cover it reads, "Please Return To Patients Library". I didn't. I still have it in my library. Perhaps in keeping it it has magical properties like a cursed monkey paw...

The following of such thematic designs through one's life should be, I think, the true purpose of autobiography.²

Which seems rather appropriate given my current status as a public villain. I am often accused of not taking matters seriously enough. It is a necessary aspect of the self-reflexive life. I cannot say that at the time I had any sense of the story to come... merely that it would somehow give that time of

“cancel culture” some context and meaning. ### 2021/05/19: Literally reading Lolita as a bedtime story Meanwhile, this vampire, for all his acting aspirations - had little sense of his role in this greater drama, and simply saw this as a way to try and take some moral high ground that he’d publicly lost long ago.

As it happens, I have since visited jail in no small part thanks to this sort of fiction. Of relevance, it had been exposed as part of a larger “cancel culture” movement that I met my wife when she was half my age... and that I literally read her Lolita as a bedtime story.

That spring of 2021, Isi had moved out from our home in Colorado and found herself in Asheville. Coincident with this, a small group of detractors, perhaps sensing a chink in our armor, began a campaign of “cancel culture” against my wife, her company, and me. In this effort, no virtual stone was left unturned, and a particular post from fifteen years prior surfaced.

2007/08/20, 06:11: Reading Lolita to a 19 Year Old

I am absolutely guilty of reading a 19 year old girl Lolita as a bedtime story for years without a shred of irony. Mostly the road-trip portions of the story. I read from the very book I stole when I was her age. And yes, my now eighteen years old son still plays too many video games. Having attended Catholic school, I do not think he’s read Nabokov.

So that part is very true. But the story of how she and I met has been fantastically fictionalized. You see, some time ago, Isi had made a YouTube video featuring an entirely fictional account of how we met. It involved her getting into Cafe de Paris in London at 17 (it’s a 21+ club), her friends leaving to hang out with the rapper 50 Cent, me ordering her lobster, getting her drunk on champagne from across the room after which I took this underaged girl back to my room for sex and bondage. It’s amazing but

every word of what she said was wrong. Here it is worth reflecting on the nature of “reality” in the age of social media. Isi has a very vivid imagination and her relationship with “reality” is tenuous, if beautiful. It is as if the “reality” of living a fabulous fairy tale gave her license to fictionalize even more fabulousness. “Reality” - always in quotes, writes Nabokov. So it is perhaps somewhat forgivable that this vampire and others villainized me. Not that anyone has asked for forgiveness, or asked at all, for that matter.

The actual story of how we met involves none of those fictional elements and is altogether more interesting - and perhaps more bizarre...

L'affaire The Enchanter

“How can I come to terms with myself?” he thought, when he did any thinking at all.³

I picked up a copy of *The Enchanter* in the Strand in Manhattan while waiting to meet Lola and her parents for lunch.

This cannot be lechery. Coarse carnality is omnivorous; the subtle kind presupposes eventual satiation.³

Yes, exactly so. True and Beautiful.

Oh, no, to me it's not a degree of a generic whole, but something totally divorced from the generic, something that is not more valuable but invaluable.³

Had I finished reading it at the time, perhaps I would have been more expectant of the precipitous downfall to come.

She was looking and screaming, but the enchanter did not yet hear her screams; he was deafened by his own horror.³

Two and a half months later, I sat in jail, convinced this was the evil doings of the overprotective parents that I had met for lunch. It must be a mistake. We were in Love. It was True. It was Beautiful.

Lola called in to my preliminary hearing at the jail to make sure the judge knew that she I caused her serious emotional distress exactly as required by C.R.S. §18-3-602.

April 28 was the day Lola decided that she was terrified and decided to contact the deputy. I had returned the night before from a road trip to deliver Isi her parrots in Asheville, just about nearly ready to move on with my life.

At 11:14am, I wrote:

I am home from my adventure to get Isi her birds. She didn't even come to receive them, and hasn't spoken to me or G- since. I feel bad for her... but happy she has her birds and that it's behind me. As for you... there is still a minute of hope. Whatever you thought, whatever you were told, whatever you did, really doesn't excuse your inability to communicate with me. But if you are the sort of person that can discard her dreams without a thought... my world is not for you. My world is for the brave young woman who pursued her dreams and stood up for what was True and Beautiful. You remain the woman I Love. I have no doubt that you belong with me, and I will not change a thing from my path to be with you. I am a good man. I am a better man for my love of you. Our life together was beautiful, and I will make your Dreams reality, whether you have the sense to be here or not. I love you. I continue to love you. You seem to want to teach me that Love does not conquer all. We shall see... I am confident that your destiny is with me. My Love for you grows by the day. I learn and I grow and I continue to become everything you desire. I think it will conquer the childish fears you have embraced. You may yet prove me wrong, but I will Love you until I die, and fully expect your return to me everyday. D She proved me wrong. She was apparently so terrified by this that very late that

night (midnight her time) she contacted the El Paso County deputy... by text message. On April 28, 2022, when I was contacted by Lola, she initially sent a text message stating who she was and requested a telephone call. At approximately 2153 hours, I contacted Lola at telephone number (xxx) xxx-xxxx. To put a fine point on it, my fiancée... in New York City... had the cell phone number of a deputy in Colorado Springs... sent him a text message and spoke to him at midnight on a Thursday... about a previous investigation... that she was aware of... that I had no knowledge of...

On April 28, 2022, I, Deputy Daniel Carey 18031, of the El Paso County Sheriff's Office (EPSO), received contact via telephone from a female party identified as Lola (DOB xx/xx/xxxx). Lola was aware of my previous investigation into D (DOB 05/06/1972); reference EPS Case Report 2021-xxxxxxx.

At 11:56pm, not three minutes after their telephone call began, I emailed her...

Subject: I love you.

I absolutely understand. Good luck, my love. I am so blessed to have known you. Thank you. Thank you. Thank you.

I still feel blessed and grateful to have known her.

On May 3, I wrote

Whatever game it is you need to play to convince your parents that you are not deviant is yours to play. Do not expect me to play it with them. Instead, expect me to love you forever. Every day I find myself wondering how it is that I love you so much. You - and your deviance - are what I desire. And I am undoubtedly what you desire and what you need. The sooner you come to terms with this reality, the better.

Whatever has happened, whatever it happened, really does not matter. If you showed up on my doorstep tomorrow, I would marry you then and there. Let me love you. Let me teach you, let me guide you. I can make you happy, make your dreams come true.

I know you can't. Your family would rather destroy you than let you become something they disapprove of. And you are willing to destroy us for them. That's not love. It's abuse. I know that you know this.

Whatever it is that you try to justify this is a lie. It is, by nature, false. Truth is that you belong with me. You've seen this, and to deny it now condemns you to a life of depression and hopelessness. Isi knows this all too well. I thought you were better than her, but you seem to insist on her stupidity. That you chose to be Isi 2.0 is just unbelievably ridiculous. So, I don't believe it. Neither do you.

So let's stop this silly game and return to the world where you are happy and dreams come true.

I am going to California in a couple weeks. Come with me... it is a rare opportunity for a second chance. The Universe wants you with me. Are you really brave enough to deny it?

First step is to simply unblock me on WhatsApp, and we see if I'm right...

I am right. D

Of course, I wasn't right. The Universe didn't want her with me. It terrified her, and she was brave enough to deny it.

After reviewing Lola's messages from D, she confirmed on numerous occasions how "terrified" she was of being physically assaulted by D. Lola also voiced concerns of retaliation from D as a result of her participation in this investigation. When asked if she wished to continue to pursue this matter in a court of law, Lola confirmed, "yes". Lola did confirm the most

recent email she received (see above) caused her serious distress and concern for her safety.⁴ Serious distress and concern for her safety. Never doubt that words are powerful. And so, here we are. The tragedy plays out as it must, again and again, until I learn something even more subtle about Truth and Beauty and Love than I knew before.

Perhaps you find this a strange, strange thing—and strangest of all, perhaps, is that, under the pretext of discussing something remarkable, I am merely seeking justification for my guilt.³

I'm waiting in this cell because I have to know... have I been guilty all this time?⁵ ### L'affaire Reverie I have just finished eating and am going to stretch out on the couch, as I must do everyday for an hour and a half, after which, for the rest of the afternoon, I plan to write a part of a very long study on Nabokov, a study which has greatly preoccupied me for the past months. As I wallow in woeful imposter syndrome at the greatness of Nabokov, I have found an amusing distraction^[2] that feels appropriate. In 1931 (15 years prior to *Lolita*, 8 years prior to *The Enchanter*), Salvador Dali published “*Reverie, An Erotic Daydream*”. I sit here on my couch reading it while drinking iced tea.

As an “experimentalist” who specializes in dominant/sadistic fantasies (thank you bdsmttest.org), I appreciate the nature of this work. It is an evolving masturbatory reverie - a fantasy. The narrator - a painter - is meditating on a painting of Vermeer. Hopefully reproduced here for I doubt entirely that any of my readers are also art historians. It's not important if it's not there, just know there is a curtain on the right. Dali's protagonist imagines some cows behind that curtain, in a stable, filled with cow dung (because he loves the stench), where he sodomizes the woman he loves. This then morphs (as fantasies do) into a scenario where now he is appreciably older, and the setting is a castle-farm some friends lend him that he stayed at when he was ten. There are gardens, and importantly - a fountain (ferruginous, not white) surrounded by cypress trees. The narrator

continues to evolve the fantasy as if designing a scene in a SecondLife sim. As the story unfolds, the reverie continues to refold. Locations are refined, vantage points are changed, architecture is modified. The woman he loves is replaced by a 12 year old girl. The little girl's name is... Dulita.

Her existence in the fantasy necessitates other plot elements for the reverie - her mother is a widow and madly in love with him; the mother consents to help him sodomize her daughter, going so far as to travel to find a old prostitute he knew who is extraordinarily perverse and experienced. It feels very Marquis de Sade. All this to "initiate" Dulita... by the fountain. The scheme is very schemey. I won't go into details. But, wait, the Cypress trees are obscuring his view of the initiation from his vantage in the castle. So they must be subject to a freak fire some time ago. And it goes on like this...

What I appreciate is that this is very much how novels (and fetish scenes and Burning Man camps and my life) come into existence. We scheme, we create, we write, we encounter obstacles, we destroy, we erase, we overcome, we recreate.

It is difficult to express how rare it is to find someone to scheme for in this fashion. Someone who appreciates the artistry and the surreality is, well, unlikely. That Lola came to me wanting to live my strange dream, knowing "all about" me and accepting me for what I was, well, that was something special. I respected and honored her love and her dreams as I thought she did mine. When it happens that she suddenly and viciously rejects it... what must I think? What should I do? The humiliation and the panicked urge to undo myself as The Enchanter was palpable.

L'affaire The Secret Life of Dali

"You shall be Dullita." She drew back, startled by the uncouthness of my emotional state, and did not answer. The exteriorization of my first urge

toward her must indeed have betrayed such tyrannical intentions that I understood it would be difficult for me now to regain the child's confidence.⁶ As *The Enchanter to Lolita*, so *Reverie* is to *The Secret Life of Salvador Dali*. Published in 1942, 11 years after *Reverie*, it is more properly akin to Nabokov's memoir *Invitation of a Memory*. This version is more refined, a complete fragment of a memory rather than the evolution of a fantasy. Dullita is Dali's fetishized little girl - replacing his lost first love.

Loves of this kind, ever more unreal and unfulfilled, allowed my feelings to overflow from one girl's image to another, even in the midst of the worst tempests of my soul, progressively strengthening my idea of continuity and reincarnation which had come to light for the first time in my encounter with my first Dullita. That is to say, I reached by degrees the conviction that I was really always in love with the same unique, obsessing feminine image, which merely multiplied itself and successively assumed different aspects, depending more and more on the all-powerful autocracy of my royal and anarchic will.⁶

Upon learning of our engagement, and seeing only her heavily filtered little girl profile photo, my good friend Stefan messaged me concerned about the optics of me being engaged to a 9 year old after the whole pedophile/grooming cancel culture nonsense above. I'm pretty sure that everyone just assumes that I have a type, and that that type is borderline immoral. Lola's friend asked her if she was "Isi 2.0". As you've read, she and I talked about this fairly often. About how "Isi actually setup this fairytale" for her. To my mind, Lola is nothing like Isi, even in spite of her precipitous failure.

Still, I wonder if I allow my feelings to overflow from one girl's image to another, if it is that I am always in love with the same girl. I do not find attraction easily. Lola was, in my mind, an artist. Art was something I found attractive.

The icing on the Nabokov-Dali mimic system features this photograph from LIFE magazine's Picture of the Week on April 7, 1941.

'Enchanting' the grounds at Hampton Manor, Dalí plants a bare-busted manikin waist-deep in a frog pond. When spring comes he intends to 'enchant' the whole place. LIFE, April 7, 1941 Picture of the Week Art imitates life. First note the "enchantment" in the original caption. Now read in Lolita... I was slow in reacting to it, and her bare knees rubbed and knocked impatiently against each other. Dimly there came into view: a surrealist painter relaxing, supine, on a beach, and near him, likewise supine, a plaster replica of the Venus de Milo, half-buried in sand. Picture of the Week, said the legend. I whisked the whole obscene thing away.¹ Dali's Reverie is obscene. As am I. As is what I would have done with Lola... as is how I have abused Lolita. Then the reverie comes to an end, because I have just realized that for some time I have been analyzing in an objective fashion the reverie under whose influence I have just been and I am directly annotating with the most scrupulous regard.⁷

L'affaire LOLA

This is the writing of one of those incredible novels where the author, in a fit of lucid madness, has set himself certain unique rules that he observes, certain nightmare obstacles that he surmounts, with the zest of a deity building a live world from the most unlikely ingredients—rocks, and carbon, and blind throbbings.² I wanted to make this beautiful. Nabokov is able to use the morally abhorrent vehicles of pedophilia, incest, and literary criticism to deliver truth and beauty.

I don't think that an artist should bother about his audience. His best audience is the person he sees in his shaving mirror every morning. I think that the audience an artist imagines, when he imagines that kind of a thing, is a room filled with people wearing his own mask.

I mimic. Inspired by the fictions and the structure of Nabokov's work, I wanted to create something at least interesting and unexpected from my morally corrupt world. Exhibitionism isn't one of my fetishes. I am not into gossip or revealing the intimacies of my relationships. But the fact that my hideous mugshot was on the morning news rather changes my relationship with you, my public.

Lola is safe - and I am safe.¹ Whether there was ever any credible threat or cause for her emotional distress is for my jury to decide. What I have madly possessed was not she, but my own creation, another, fanciful Lola - perhaps, more real than Lola; overlapping, encasing her; floating between me and her, and having no will, no consciousness - indeed, no life of her own.¹ I used her. I use her still. I loved Lola the girl, but Lola the ghost now inspires me. She inspires these very words.

Nabokov teaches, "Literature is invention. Fiction is fiction. To call a story a true story is an insult to both art and truth."⁸ Herein, I insult both art and truth. I tell myself that publishing this is a dimetic display - that I am not actually a danger to you. But we both know that it is aposematic to protect you from the "reality" that is dangerous. Lola's parents certainly don't want to know the depths of their daughter's depraved interests. But maybe they are self-congratulatory that they have protected her from me. ### L'affaire Ada Do fireflies burn one if they fly into you?⁹ Fireflies produce a cold light - no infrared or ultraviolet - just hues of yellow, green, maybe a pale red. The enzyme luciferase acts on the luciferin, in the presence of magnesium ions, ATP, and oxygen to produce light. In science, we use luciferase extensively to attach to proteins and make molecules glow. It differs from the Green Fluorescent Protein in that it does not actually require an external light source, but it does require the luciferin and ATP. Once upon a time when I pretended to know about metabolic engineering, I had schemes for two beers that would be made from genetically modified yeast - "LuciferAle" and GFP IPA. LuciferAle would require the addition of ATP to make it glow. I thought it would look great in a nightclub.

The fireflies also use this for communication and mate selection. Some species, especially lightning bugs of the genera *Photinus* and *Photuris*, are distinguished by the unique courtship flash patterns emitted by flying males in search of females.

The males of the firefly, a small luminous beetle, more like a wandering star than a winged insect, appeared on the first warm black nights of Ardis, one by one, here and there, then in a ghostly multitude, dwindling again to a few individuals as their quest came to its natural end...⁹ Fireflies flashing in unison is a mesmerizing manifestation of animal collective behavior and an archetype of biological synchrony.

The phenomenon of nuptial gift transfer during mating occurs across a remarkably wide range of taxa, and such male donations are likely to influence both pre-copulatory and post-copulatory sexual selection.¹⁰

In general, the females of the genus *Photinus* do not fly, but do give a flash response to males of their own species.

Female “femme fatale” *Photuris* fireflies mimic these photic signaling patterns of the tinier *Photinus*¹¹, attracting males to what appears to be a suitable mate... and then devour them. This provides the females with a supply of the toxic defensive lucibufagin chemicals which they use to protect their children from predators.

I would say that looking back, it definitely seemed predatory and like she was grooming me⁴ #### La Bibliographie 1. Nabokov, V. *Lolita*. 2. Nabokov, V. *Speak, Memory*. 3. Nabokov, V. *The Eye*. 4. Carey, D. *Arrest Warrant*. 5. Pink Floyd. *Stop*. 6. Dali, S. *The Secret Life of Salvador Dali*. 7. Dali, S. *The Reverie*. 8. Nabokov, V. *Good Readers and Good Writers*. in. 9. Nabokov, V. *Ada*. 10. Lewis, S. M., Cratsley, C. K. & Rooney, J. A. Nuptial Gifts and Sexual Selection in *Photinus* Fireflies¹. *Integrative and Comparative Biology* 44, 234–237 (2004). 11. Lloyd, J. E. Aggressive Mimicry in *Photuris*: Firefly Femmes Fatales. *Science* 149, 653–

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